Verb Tenses
Diagnostic Assessment

200 Questions

Reasoning-Based • Not Rule-Recall

Target learner: ages 12–13 (a strong Grade 6 student)

Long-term goal: SAT readiness

Scope: Verb Tenses only

Design: reasoning-based diagnosis, not rule recall

Name: _____

Date: _____ Score: _____ / 200

Student Instructions

- Read every question slowly. Several look easy but hide a trap.
- Choose your answer from the **meaning and situation**, not only from a signal word such as 'yesterday' or 'since'.
- For multiple-choice items, write the letter of your choice. For a 'Choose ALL correct answers' item, more than one letter may be right.
- For fill-in, correction, rewrite, and writing tasks, write neatly on the lines provided.
- Do **not** open the Answer Key until you have finished the whole paper.
- If two answers both seem possible, pick the one that best fits the situation, and be ready to explain why the other is weaker.
- Attempt every question. An answer that shows your thinking is more useful to your teacher than a blank.
- There is no strict clock. Work in focused blocks and keep your reasoning honest.

Assessment Overview

This paper treats grammar as **decision-making**, not memorisation. The goal is not to check whether you can recite tense rules; it is to reveal whether your mental model of English time actually works when the sentence fights back.

The 200 questions attack verb tenses from many independent angles: routines and facts, actions in progress, completed events, the order of two past events, duration up to now, plans and predictions, stative verbs, irregular forms, and paragraph-level consistency. No two questions repeat the same trick in a row.

Difficulty rises in three waves. **Level 1** items reward meaning over signal words. **Level 2** items combine sequence, duration, interruption, completion, and present relevance. **Level 3** items place several tempting options side by side, where only one truly fits the context.

Every wrong option in this paper was chosen on purpose. Each represents a specific, believable misconception. When you review with the Answer Key, you will see not just the right answer but the exact thinking error each wrong answer would come from.

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Question Paper

Section 0 — Warm-Up: Core Tense Recognition

A short, easy start to settle in. Match the tense to the situation. These should feel comfortable.

Q1. [Multiple choice] Every morning, my grandfather ____ a long walk in the park.

- **(A)** takes
- **(B)** is taking
- **(C)** took
- **(D)** has taken

Q2. [Fill in the blank] Fill the blank with the correct form of the verb in brackets. — Water ____ (boil) at 100 degrees Celsius at sea level.

Q3. [Multiple choice] Look! The baby ____ at you.

- **(A)** smiles
- **(B)** is smiling
- **(C)** smiled
- **(D)** smile

Q4. [Fill in the blank] Yesterday, our class ____ (visit) the science museum.

Q5. [Multiple choice] By the time we reached the hall, the concert ____.

- **(A)** already started
- **(B)** had already started
- **(C)** has already started
- **(D)** starts

Q6. [Fill in the blank] She ____ (live) in this city since 2019.

Q7. [Multiple choice] 'You look worried. Don't panic — I ____ help you with your project.'

- **(A)** am helping
- **(B)** help
- **(C)** will help
- **(D)** helped

Q8. [Fill in the blank] Quiet, please! The students ____ (write) a test right now.

Q9. [Multiple choice] My mother ____ to work by metro every single day.

- **(A)** is going

(B) goes
(C) has gone
(D) went

Q10. [Fill in the blank] The sun ____ (rise) in the east and ____ (set) in the west.

Section A — Present Tense Nuance

Habit vs. now, permanent vs. temporary, and finished-with-relevance vs. duration-up-to-now. Watch the stative-verb traps.

Q11. [Multiple choice] I ____ the answer to this difficult question.

(A) am knowing
(B) know
(C) have been knowing
(D) knows

Q12. [Multiple choice] Read the two sentences. (1) 'My cousin is staying with us this week.' (2) 'My cousin stays with us.' Which sentence shows a temporary, short-term visit?

(A) Sentence 1
(B) Sentence 2
(C) Both, equally
(D) Neither

Q13. [Fill in the blank] We ____ (be) close friends since primary school.

Q14. [Correct the sentence] Rewrite this sentence correctly: 'I am not understanding this chapter at all.'

Q15. [Multiple choice] 'Where is Meera?' 'She ____ to the dentist — she will be back by five.'

(A) has gone
(B) has been
(C) is going
(D) goes

Q16. [Choose ALL correct answers] Which of these sentences are correct as written? Choose ALL that apply.

(A) 'I am living in a hotel until my new flat is ready.'
(B) 'I am owning three bicycles.'
(C) 'The Earth is going around the Sun.'
(D) 'These days, I am walking to school because my bus route changed.'

Q17. [Explain the error] Explain why this sounds wrong in careful English, and give the corrected sentence: 'I am really liking this new song.'

Q18. [Multiple choice] My eyes really hurt. I ____ at this screen for three hours without a break.

(A) have been staring
(B) have stared
(C) am staring
(D) stared

Q19. [Fill in the blank] Normally I sleep very well, but these days I ____ (not / sleep) properly because of the exams.

Q20. [Which is better?] Which sentence is correct for a bicycle you got as a child and still own today?

(A) 'I have had this bicycle since I was eight.'
(B) 'I have this bicycle since I was eight.'

Q21. [Multiple choice] 'You keep changing your answer! What ____ you actually ____?'

(A) do / believe
(B) are / believing
(C) have / believed
(D) did / believe

Q22. [Rewrite (keep the meaning)] Rewrite as ONE sentence using the present perfect continuous, keeping the meaning: 'Mr. Rao started coaching our team in January. He is still coaching us now.'

Q23. [Choose the context] For which situation is 'I have lived in Pune since 2020' the correct sentence (rather than 'I lived in Pune in 2020')?

(A) You moved to Pune in 2020 and you still live there today.
(B) You lived in Pune during 2020 only and later moved away.
(C) You are planning to move to Pune next year.
(D) You visited Pune once for a week in 2020.

Q24. [Multiple choice] The speaker is complaining about an irritating, repeated habit: 'He ____ his phone somewhere; it drives me crazy!'

(A) always loses
(B) is always losing
(C) has always lost
(D) lost

Q25. [Fill in the blank] No tea for me, thanks. I ____ (prefer) coffee in the mornings.

Q26. [Are both acceptable?] Are both acceptable in standard English? (1) 'I have known Aisha for five years.' (2) 'I know Aisha for five years.'

- **(A)** Only (1) is correct
- **(B)** Only (2) is correct
- **(C)** Both are correct
- **(D)** Neither is correct

Q27. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'She has never wrote a poem before.'

Q28. [Multiple choice] Choose the correct sentence.

- **(A)** 'I have visited the Taj Mahal last year.'
- **(B)** 'I visited the Taj Mahal last year.'
- **(C)** 'I am visiting the Taj Mahal last year.'
- **(D)** 'I visit the Taj Mahal last year.'

Q29. [Explain the error] A tourist asks a shopkeeper, 'How long are you living in this town?' The shopkeeper looks confused. Explain the problem and give the correct question.

Q30. [Multiple choice] A live cricket commentator describes fast action: 'Sharma ____ the ball... and he ____ it straight to the boundary!' Which forms are typical of quick live commentary?

- **(A)** is bowling / is hitting
- **(B)** bowls / hits
- **(C)** bowled / hit
- **(D)** has bowled / has hit

Q31. [Fill in the blank] Please do not disturb her. She ____ (talk) to the principal at the moment.

Q32. [Multiple choice] In which sentence is the -ing form correct?

- **(A)** 'I am understanding the lesson now.'
- **(B)** 'I am thinking about the problem right now.'
- **(C)** 'I am knowing the answer.'
- **(D)** 'I am wanting a short break.'

Q33. [Choose the context] In which situation is 'Ravi is working at a bank' the better choice (rather than 'Ravi works at a bank')?

(A) It is Ravi's permanent, long-term profession.
(B) Ravi is a student, but he has a temporary summer job at a bank.
(C) You are naming the career Ravi has chosen for life.
(D) Ravi retired years ago and no longer works.

Q34. [Multiple choice] 'Do not offer him lunch — he ____ eaten.' (He ate a few minutes ago and is still full.)

(A) just has
(B) has just
(C) just
(D) is just

Section B — Past Tense Nuance

Completed actions, background vs. interruption, and which of two past events came first. Resist over-using the past perfect.

Q35. [Multiple choice] I ____ TV peacefully when the lights suddenly ____ out.

(A) watched / went
(B) was watching / went
(C) was watching / were going
(D) watched / were going

Q36. [Fill in the blank] When we finally reached the platform, the train ____ (already / leave).

Q37. [Which is better?] Which sentence is more natural?

(A) 'First I brushed my teeth, and then I had gone to bed.'
(B) 'First I brushed my teeth, and then I went to bed.'

Q38. [Correct the sentence] Correct the tense error: 'While she was reading, the lights suddenly went out and she was dropping her book.'

Q39. [Multiple choice] I didn't recognise the town at all. It ____ a lot since my last visit.

(A) changed
(B) had changed
(C) was changing
(D) has changed

Q40. [Multiple choice] By the time the guests finally left, we ____ for six straight hours, and the kitchen was a total mess.

(A) had been cooking
(B) cooked
(C) were cooking

(D) have been cooking

Q41. [Fill in the blank] By the time the ambulance arrived, the injured man ____ (already / lose) a great deal of blood.

Q42. [Explain the error] A student wants to say that he ate dinner AFTER getting home. He writes: 'When I reached home, I had eaten dinner.' Explain why this does not say what he means, and give the correct sentence.

Q43. [Order the events] Based on this sentence, write the three events in the order they actually happened (earliest first): 'When the manager walked in, the team had submitted the report and were celebrating quietly.'

Q44. [Fill in the blank] When the teacher walked in, the students ____ (talk) so loudly that they did not even notice her.

Q45. [Spot the error] One verb uses the past perfect where it is not needed. Find it and give the corrected verb: 'Yesterday morning I had finished my breakfast and rushed straight to school.'

Q46. [Choose ALL correct answers] In which sentences is the past perfect used correctly and usefully? Choose ALL that apply.

(A) 'By the time the firefighters arrived, the shed had burned down.'
(B) 'I had eaten breakfast, and then I had brushed my teeth, and then I had left.'
(C) 'She suddenly realised that she had forgotten her password.'
(D) 'Yesterday I had gone to the market to buy vegetables.'

Q47. [Fill in the blank] Describe the scene that was already happening as we set off. The sun ____ (shine) brightly and the birds ____ (sing) in the trees when we left the house.

Q48. [Multiple choice] The moment the final bell rang, the students ____ their books and ____ the classroom.

(A) closed / left
(B) were closing / were leaving
(C) had closed / had left
(D) close / leave

Q49. [Timeline reasoning] 'When the coach entered, the players had hidden the birthday cake and were pretending to stretch.' Which event happened FIRST?

(A) The players hid the cake
(B) The coach entered
(C) The players pretended to stretch
(D) All three happened at the same time

Q50. [Compare the sentences] Which sentence means the man was already gone before I got there? (1) 'When I arrived, he left.' (2) 'When I arrived, he had left.'

(A) Sentence 1
(B) Sentence 2
(C) Both mean the same
(D) Neither

Q51. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'I was knowing the answer, so I raised my hand.'

Q52. [Fill in the blank] Before the internet ____ (become) common, people ____ (use) handwritten letters to keep in touch.

Q53. [Multiple choice] When I was little, I ____ afraid of the dark, but I am not any more.

(A) was
(B) am
(C) have been
(D) was being

Q54. [Explain the error] Explain the difference in meaning between these two sentences: (1) 'When the film started, we ate our popcorn.' (2) 'When the film started, we had eaten our popcorn.'

Q55. [Rewrite (keep the meaning)] Combine into ONE sentence using the past perfect, keeping the meaning: 'The train left. Then we reached the platform.'

Q56. [Fill in the blank] The players were completely exhausted. They ____ (train — use the form that stresses the ongoing activity that caused it) hard for three hours before the coach let them rest.

Q57. [Multiple choice] Which option keeps the narrative consistent? 'Yesterday was strange. I woke up late, I ____ breakfast, and I ____ for the bus, but it never came.'

- **(A)** skip / wait
- **(B)** skipped / waited
- **(C)** had skipped / had waited
- **(D)** was skipping / was waiting

Q58. [Spot the error] Find the ONE verb that breaks the past-tense narrative and give the correction: 'The storm hit at midnight. Trees fell, the power went out, and everyone rushes to shut the windows.'

Section C — Future Tense Nuance

Prediction vs. plan vs. schedule, evidence-based futures, arrangements, and the future perfect. The 'obvious' future is often wrong.

Q59. [Multiple choice] 'The phone is ringing.' 'Oh, I ____ answer it.'

- **(A)** will
- **(B)** am going to
- **(C)** am answering
- **(D)** answer

Q60. [Multiple choice] You can see it in the sky right now — those heavy dark clouds mean it ____ rain very soon.

- **(A)** will
- **(B)** is going to
- **(C)** rains
- **(D)** is raining

Q61. [Fill in the blank] Hurry up! According to the timetable, the train ____ (leave) at exactly 7:15.

Q62. [Multiple choice] I can't meet you on Friday afternoon. I ____ my dentist at 4 p.m. — the appointment is already booked.

- **(A)** will see
- **(B)** am seeing
- **(C)** see
- **(D)** will be seeing

Q63. [Multiple choice] By this time next year, I ____ from secondary school.

(A) will graduate
(B) will have graduated
(C) am graduating
(D) graduate

Q64. [Fill in the blank] Don't worry about the money. I ____ (pay) you back next week, I promise.

Q65. [Multiple choice] Please don't call me at 8 tonight — I'll be right in the middle of it. I ____ dinner then.

(A) will have
(B) will be having
(C) have
(D) had

Q66. [Multiple choice] I've finally made up my mind. I ____ learn to play the guitar this year.

(A) will
(B) am going to
(C) learn
(D) am learning

Q67. [Fill in the blank] The city museum ____ (open) at 9 a.m. and ____ (close) at 6 p.m. every day of the week.

Q68. [Compare the sentences] Which sentence describes a plan that is already arranged for a definite time? (1) 'I am visiting my grandmother this weekend.' (2) 'I will visit my grandmother someday.'

(A) Sentence 1
(B) Sentence 2
(C) Both, equally
(D) Neither

Q69. [Multiple choice] The film starts at 8 p.m. and runs for two hours, so by 10:30 it ____.

(A) will end
(B) will have ended
(C) ends
(D) is ending

Q70. [Correct the sentence] Correct the future form: 'Look out! You will drop the vase!' (You can see it is about to slip from his hands.)

Q71. [Multiple choice] According to the official timetable, our final exam ____ next Monday at 10 a.m.

(A) is

(B) is being
(C) will be being
(D) was

Q72. [Fill in the blank] Many scientists believe that robots ____ (do) most dangerous jobs in the future.

Q73. [Multiple choice] A: 'We've run out of milk.' B: 'Oh, ____ some on my way home.'

(A) I'll buy
(B) I'm going to buy
(C) I buy
(D) I'm buying

Q74. [Multiple choice] We ____ our new neighbours to dinner on Saturday; the table is booked and everything is arranged.

(A) will invite
(B) are inviting
(C) invite
(D) will be inviting

Q75. [Explain the error] For a plan already arranged with friends, which is more natural, and why? 'I will meet my friends at the mall tomorrow; we arranged it last week.'

Q76. [Multiple choice] I will call you as soon as I ____ home.

(A) will reach
(B) reach
(C) am reaching
(D) will have reached

Q77. [Fill in the blank] If it ____ (rain) tomorrow, we will move the picnic indoors.

Q78. [Multiple choice] This time tomorrow, we ____ high above the Atlantic Ocean on our flight to New York.

(A) will fly
(B) will be flying
(C) fly
(D) are flying

Q79. [Are both acceptable?] Are both acceptable ways to predict the weather? (1) 'I think it will snow tonight.' (2) 'I think it is going to snow tonight.'

(A) Only (1) is correct

(B) Only (2) is correct
(C) Both are acceptable
(D) Neither is correct

Q80. [Multiple choice] I ____ always be there for you, no matter what happens.

(A) will
(B) am going to
(C) am
(D) am being

Q81. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'When I will grow up, I will become a pilot.'

Q82. [Multiple choice] A: 'What are your plans for the summer?' B: 'Well, I ____ a coding course in June — I've already enrolled — and after that I ____ visit my cousins, though I haven't fixed any dates.'

(A) am taking / am going to
(B) will take / will
(C) take / am taking
(D) am going to take / am visiting

Section D — Perfect Tense Reasoning

Present perfect vs. simple past, past perfect vs. simple past, future perfect, and the logic behind since / for / already / yet / by the time.

Q83. [Multiple choice] She ____ three cups of coffee so far today, and it is only 10 a.m.

(A) drank
(B) has drunk
(C) drinks
(D) is drinking

Q84. [Fill in the blank] They ____ (know) each other for more than twenty years.

Q85. [Multiple choice] Shakespeare ____ many of the most famous plays in the English language.

(A) has written
(B) wrote
(C) had written
(D) writes

Q86. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'I have seen that film last night.'

Q87. [Multiple choice] ____ you ever ____ to Japan? I mean at any point in your life.

(A) Did / go
(B) Have / been

(C) Have / gone
(D) Do / go

Q88. [Fill in the blank] This is the best pizza I ____ (ever / eat)!

Q89. [Multiple choice] You've missed her by a minute. She ____ left the building.

(A) just
(B) has just
(C) just has
(D) had just

Q90. [Explain the error] Explain when you would use each sentence: (1) 'I have lost my umbrella.' (2) 'I lost my umbrella.'

Q91. [Multiple choice] By the time the teacher collected the answer sheets, most students ____ only half of the questions.

(A) answered
(B) had answered
(C) have answered
(D) were answering

Q92. [Fill in the blank] Please don't arrive at 6. By then I ____ (not / finish) cooking, and the food won't be ready.

Q93. [Multiple choice] We have been standing here ____ 45 minutes, ____ the doors first opened.

(A) since / for
(B) for / since
(C) for / for
(D) since / since

Q94. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'We are living in this house since 2018.'

Q95. [Multiple choice] A: 'Have you sent the report?' B: 'Yes, I've ____ sent it — earlier than the deadline.'

(A) yet
(B) already
(C) still
(D) ever

Q96. [Fill in the blank] I'm sorry, I haven't finished reading your essay ____.

Q97. [Multiple choice] 'Why are you so out of breath right now?' 'Because I ____ to catch the bus.'

(A) have run
(B) have been running
(C) run
(D) ran

Q98. [Multiple choice] Look how much she has done! She ____ ten thank-you cards already.

(A) has written
(B) has been writing
(C) wrote
(D) writes

Q99. [Explain the error] Explain why this is wrong and correct it: 'I have been reading this book three times.'

Q100. [Multiple choice] Call me any time after 9 tonight; I ____ dinner by then.

(A) will finish
(B) will have finished
(C) finish
(D) am finishing

Q101. [Fill in the blank] By the time you read this note, I ____ (already / leave) for the airport.

Q102. [Multiple choice] It's wonderful to see you again! A lot ____ since we last met.

(A) happened
(B) has happened
(C) had happened
(D) happens

Q103. [Are both acceptable?] Are both acceptable? (1) 'I have finished my work, so I can go home now.' (2) 'I finished my work, so I can go home now.'

(A) Only (1) is correct
(B) Only (2) is correct
(C) Both are acceptable; (1) stresses the present result
(D) Neither is correct

Q104. [Multiple choice] By the time Ravi turns eighteen next month, he ____ in six different cities, because his family ____ so often over the years.

(A) will have lived / has moved
(B) lived / moved
(C) will live / moves
(D) has lived / had moved

Section E — Time Markers vs. Real Meaning

Signal words are clues, not commands. Here the context sometimes overrules the obvious marker. Read for meaning.

Q105. [Multiple choice] It is now 4 p.m. I ____ several emails this morning, but this afternoon I have been stuck in meetings.

(A) have written
(B) wrote
(C) write
(D) had written

Q106. [Multiple choice] Please don't be upset with me — I ____ want to help you, nothing more.

(A) have just wanted
(B) just want
(C) just wanted
(D) am just wanting

Q107. [Multiple choice] Since you ____ Spanish so fluently, could you translate this letter for me?

(A) have spoken
(B) speak
(C) spoke
(D) are speaking

Q108. [Multiple choice] These days, I ____ to school because the roads near my house are being repaired.

(A) walk
(B) am walking
(C) walked
(D) have walked

Q109. [Are both acceptable?] Are both acceptable? (1) 'I have recently read a wonderful book.' (2) 'I recently read a wonderful book.'

(A) Only (1) is correct
(B) Only (2) is correct
(C) Both are acceptable
(D) Neither is correct

Q110. [Multiple choice] I'll send you a message the moment the film ____.

(A) will end
(B) ends
(C) ended

(D) is ending

Q111. [Multiple choice] My grandmother ____ a kind word for everyone she meets; she always has, and everyone loves her for it.

(A) has
(B) is having
(C) had
(D) will have

Q112. [Fill in the blank] It is late at night now, and I am exhausted. I ____ (do) so much today that I can barely keep my eyes open.

Q113. [Multiple choice] I ____ her three years ago, and we ____ good friends ever since.

(A) have met / have been
(B) met / have been
(C) met / are
(D) have met / are

Q114. [Multiple choice] 'Has the post arrived?' 'Yes, the postman ____ it just now.'

(A) has delivered
(B) delivered
(C) delivers
(D) had delivered

Q115. [Multiple choice] You look worn out. ____ you ____ enough sleep lately?

(A) Did / get
(B) Have / been getting
(C) Do / get
(D) Had / got

Q116. [Explain the error] A student always chooses the simple past whenever she sees 'yesterday'. Explain why this sentence still needs the past perfect: 'By yesterday evening, the workers had already repaired the broken road.'

Q117. [Multiple choice] When I was a child, we ____ to the seaside every single summer.

(A) go
(B) went
(C) have gone
(D) had gone

Q118. [Fill in the blank] So far this season, our school team ____ (win) every single match they have played.

Q119. [Multiple choice] The moment the teacher ____ the results, I will run to tell you.

- **(A)** will announce
- **(B)** announces
- **(C)** announced
- **(D)** is announcing

Q120. [Multiple choice] Choose the set that fits: 'As soon as the bell ____, we ____ home, and by the time we get there, dinner ____ ready and waiting.'

- **(A)** rings / will go / will be
- **(B)** will ring / go / is
- **(C)** rings / go / is
- **(D)** rings / will go / is

Section F — Irregular Verbs Inside Tense Contexts

Irregular verbs tested where they live: inside real tense decisions, where the form and the tense must both be right.

Q121. [Multiple choice] The film had already ____ by the time we found our seats.

- **(A)** began
- **(B)** begun
- **(C)** begin
- **(D)** beginning

Q122. [Fill in the blank] I have never ____ (see) such a beautiful sunset in my whole life.

Q123. [Multiple choice] ____ you ____ your subjects for next year yet?

- **(A)** Did / chose
- **(B)** Have / chosen
- **(C)** Have / choose
- **(D)** Did / chosen

Q124. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'Someone has broke the classroom window.'

Q125. [Multiple choice] By the time she reached the shop, she ____ what she had planned to buy.

- **(A)** forgot
- **(B)** had forgotten
- **(C)** has forgotten
- **(D)** forgets

Q126. [Fill in the blank] The school choir ____ (sing) three lovely songs at yesterday's concert.

Q127. [Multiple choice] She ____ my pen about an hour ago and still hasn't given it back.

(A) has taken
(B) took
(C) had taken
(D) taken

Q128. [Fill in the blank] Have you ever ____ (speak) to someone famous in real life?

Q129. [Multiple choice] By next Friday, I ____ all five of my essays and can finally relax.

(A) will write
(B) will have written
(C) wrote
(D) have written

Q130. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'I have went to the dentist twice this month.'

Q131. [Multiple choice] Yesterday, my cousin ____ me a lovely gift from her trip abroad.

(A) has brought
(B) brought
(C) had brought
(D) brings

Q132. [Multiple choice] Mr. Khan ____ at our school since 2015 and still teaches us today.

(A) taught
(B) has taught
(C) had taught
(D) teaches

Q133. [Fill in the blank] The concert ____ (begin) at 7 p.m. sharp yesterday, but by 7:30 the singer ____ (already / begin) her third song.

Q134. [Multiple choice] Last week, our club ____ a brand-new captain for the season.

(A) has chosen
(B) chose
(C) had chosen
(D) chosen

Q135. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'I seen him at the mall yesterday.'

Q136. [Multiple choice] Choose the correct set: 'I ____ that movie three times already: I first ____ it back in 2022, and I ____ it again just last week.'

- **(A)** have seen / saw / saw
- **(B)** saw / have seen / have seen
- **(C)** have seen / have seen / saw
- **(D)** saw / saw / saw

Section G — Stative Verbs and the Continuous Trap

Verbs of state, thought, feeling, and possession that usually resist the -ing form. Reject the tempting but unnatural continuous.

Q137. [Multiple choice] This old wooden box ____ all of my grandmother's letters.

- **(A)** is containing
- **(B)** contains
- **(C)** is contained
- **(D)** contain

Q138. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'I am believing that honesty is always the best policy.'

Q139. [Multiple choice] In which sentence is the -ing form of 'have' CORRECT?

- **(A)** 'I am having a brand-new laptop.'
- **(B)** 'We are having a wonderful time at the fair.'
- **(C)** 'She is having lovely brown eyes.'
- **(D)** 'They are having three children.'

Q140. [Fill in the blank] Mmm, this fresh bread ____ (smell) absolutely wonderful.

Q141. [Multiple choice] The chef ____ the sauce right now to check it, and she says it ____ just perfect.

- **(A)** tastes / is tasting
- **(B)** is tasting / tastes
- **(C)** is tasting / is tasting
- **(D)** tastes / tastes

Q142. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'This suitcase is weighing exactly twenty kilograms.'

Q143. [Multiple choice] This maths problem ____ difficult at first, but it is actually easy once you spot the trick.

- **(A)** is seeming

(B) seems
(C) seem
(D) is seemed

Q144. [Fill in the blank] I'm so sorry — I ____ (not / remember) your name at all.

Q145. [Multiple choice] Whose umbrella is this? It ____ to someone who sat in the front row.

(A) is belonging
(B) belongs
(C) belong
(D) is belonged

Q146. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'These new football boots are costing far too much for me.'

Q147. [Multiple choice] In which sentence is 'am thinking' used correctly?

(A) 'I am thinking he is the best captain.'
(B) 'I am thinking of joining the debate club next term.'
(C) 'I am thinking that water is wet.'
(D) 'I am thinking this film is boring.'

Q148. [Fill in the blank] She ____ (want) to become a doctor ever since she was five years old.

Q149. [Multiple choice] We ____ a little more time to finish this project properly.

(A) are needing
(B) need
(C) needs
(D) is needing

Q150. [Correct the sentence] Correct this sentence: 'Right now, I am wanting a tall glass of cold water.'

Q151. [Multiple choice] Choose the fully correct sentence.

(A) 'I am seeing that you are upset, and I am wanting to help.'
(B) 'I see that you are upset, and I want to help.'
(C) 'I see that you are upsetting, and I am wanting to help.'
(D) 'I am seeing that you upset, and I want to help.'

Q152. [Explain the error] Explain why 'I am seeing the doctor tomorrow' is correct, but 'I am seeing a rainbow right now' is wrong. Give the correct form of the second sentence.

Section H — Sequence, Consistency and Narrative Tense

Ordering events, keeping a paragraph consistent, and spotting the one tense that breaks the flow of a story, diary, email, or notice.

Q153. [Paragraph editing] This story is told in the past tense, but one verb is in the wrong tense. Find it and write the correct form. 'Last Saturday, Mia woke up early and made breakfast for everyone. After they ate, the family drove to the lake. Mia jumps into the cold water and laughed with her brothers all afternoon.'

Q154. [Order the events] Read the sentence, then number the two events 1 (happened first) and 2 (happened second): 'When the firefighters arrived, the family had already escaped from the burning house.' ( ) The firefighters arrived. ( ) The family escaped.

Q155. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best sets the background scene. 'As we walked into the garden, the birds ___ in the trees.'

(A) 'sang'
(B) 'were singing'
(C) 'have sung'
(D) 'sing'

Q156. [Spot the error] One sentence in this paragraph shifts to the wrong tense. Write the sentence number and correct the verb. '(1) The old lighthouse stood on the cliff for a hundred years. (2) One stormy night, the keeper climbed the stairs to light the lamp. (3) Suddenly, the wind blows out his candle. (4) He fumbled in the dark until he found the matches.'

Q157. [Paragraph editing] Fill each blank with the correct past-tense form to keep the narrative consistent. 'The detective ___ (enter) the room and ___ (look) around carefully. Nothing ___ (seem) out of place, but she ___ (know) that something was wrong.'

Q158. [Complete the dialogue] Read the dialogue and choose the correct option. Ben: 'You look exhausted!' Sam: 'I know. I ___ since six o'clock this morning.' Which best completes Sam's line?

(A) 'have been studying'
(B) 'studied'
(C) 'was studying'
(D) 'study'

Q159. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that correctly sequences the two past events. 'By the time the guests arrived, my mother ___ the entire meal.'

(A) 'cooked'
(B) 'had cooked'
(C) 'was cooking'
(D) 'cooks'

Q160. [Timeline reasoning] Describe a simple timeline (earliest to now) that places these events in order, based on the sentence: 'I had lived in three different cities before I moved to London, where I have lived ever since.'

Q161. [Correct the sentence] Correct the tense error in this sentence: 'While I was walked to school, I saw a fox cross the road.'

Q162. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that keeps the sentence consistent. 'She opened the fridge, took out the milk, and ___ herself a glass.'

(A) 'pours'
(B) 'had poured'
(C) 'poured'
(D) 'was pouring'

Q163. [Are both acceptable?] Both sentences are grammatically correct. Explain how their meanings differ. (1) 'When I got home, my sister made dinner.' (2) 'When I got home, my sister had made dinner.'

Q164. [Rewrite (keep the meaning)] Rewrite this present-tense narrative in the past tense, keeping it consistent: 'Tom wakes up, sees the snow, and runs outside. He builds a snowman while his dog watches.'

Q165. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that correctly completes this email. 'Dear Aunt Sara, Thank you for the birthday gift, which ___ yesterday. I love it! I will visit you next month to thank you in person.'

(A) 'arrives'
(B) 'arrived'
(C) 'has arrived'
(D) 'had arrived'

Q166. [Spot the error] This diary entry has one verb in the wrong tense. Find it and correct it, keeping the past narrative consistent. 'Dear Diary, Today was amazing. We drive to the beach and swam in the sea. I collected shells while my dad read his book. I felt so happy!'

Q167. [Choose the context] Select the verb form that best fits the ongoing story. 'The children had been playing outside for hours. By dinnertime they ___ tired and hungry.'

(A) 'are'
(B) 'were'
(C) 'have been'
(D) 'had been'

Q168. [Paragraph editing] Fill the blanks so this notice reads correctly. 'The library ___ (be) closed last week for repairs. It ___ (reopen) yesterday, and it ___ (be) now open at its usual hours.'

Q169. [Multiple choice] Choose the correct option. 'The film ___ by the time we found our seats; we had missed the opening scene.'

(A) 'already started'
(B) 'had already started'

(C) 'was already starting'

(D) 'already starts'

Q170. [Compare the sentences] Explain the difference in meaning between these two correct sentences. (1) 'When the bell rang, the students left the classroom.' (2) 'When the bell rang, the students were leaving the classroom.'

Q171. [Fill in the blank] Complete the paragraph with suitable past forms. Where two tenses are possible, either is accepted. 'The storm ___ (rage) all night. When we ___ (wake) up, the garden ___ (be) full of broken branches.'

Q172. [Order the events] Number these events 1-3 in the order they actually happened, using the tense clues: 'Before she went on stage, she had rehearsed her lines, which her teacher had written for her.' ( ) She went on stage. ( ) Her teacher wrote the lines. ( ) She rehearsed her lines.

Q173. [Spot the error] This paragraph is written in the past tense, but it contains exactly one tense error. Give the sentence number and the correction. '(1) When we arrived at the campsite, the sun was setting behind the hills. (2) We quickly put up our tent before it got dark. (3) While my father lit the fire, my sister and I collect firewood. (4) Later, we sat around the fire and told stories until we fell asleep.'

Q174. [Short writing] Write two or three sentences continuing this story. Keep the whole passage in the past tense. 'The knight opened the heavy wooden door and stepped into the dark tower...'

Section I — Expert Diagnostic Challenge

Level 3. Several options look correct at first glance. Only one best fits the full context. Slow down and justify.

Q175. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'As soon as the download ___, the program will install itself automatically.'

- **(A)** 'will finish'
- **(B)** 'finishes'
- **(C)** 'will have finished'
- **(D)** 'is finishing'

Q176. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'By the time you read this note, I ___ for the airport.'

- **(A)** 'will leave'
- **(B)** 'leave'
- **(C)** 'will have left'
- **(D)** 'am leaving'

Q177. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'I ___ Anna since we were children; she is my oldest friend.'

- **(A)** 'know'
- **(B)** 'have known'
- **(C)** 'have been knowing'
- **(D)** 'am knowing'

Q178. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'If the medicine ___ within an hour, call the doctor immediately.'

- **(A)** 'will not work'
- **(B)** 'does not work'
- **(C)** 'is not working'
- **(D)** 'would not work'

Q179. [Ambiguity analysis] The sentence 'I have been reading your book' can suggest two different things depending on the situation. Explain both, and give a context for each.

Q180. [Choose ALL correct answers] Select ALL the sentences that are grammatically correct.

- **(A)** 'I have seen him yesterday.'
- **(B)** 'I saw him yesterday.'
- **(C)** 'I have known her for years.'

(D) 'I am knowing the answer.'

(E) 'By the time we arrive, the show will have started.'

Q181. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that correctly completes this formal sentence. 'Scarcely ___ the concert begun when the power suddenly went out.'

(A) 'has'

(B) 'had'

(C) 'did'

(D) 'was'

Q182. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'This time next week, I ___ on a beach in Spain.'

(A) 'will lie'

(B) 'will be lying'

(C) 'lie'

(D) 'am lying'

Q183. [Which is better?] You have already decided to sell your bike. A friend asks about your plans. Which reply is better, and why? (1) 'I think I'll sell my bike.' (2) 'I'm going to sell my bike.'

Q184. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'Wait here until I ___ back.'

(A) 'will come'

(B) 'come'

(C) 'will have come'

(D) 'am coming'

Q185. [Explain the error] Explain why 'I have lost my keys' is different from 'I lost my keys', and describe a situation where only the first is appropriate.

Q186. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'We ___ in this town for twenty years, and we love it here.'

(A) 'live'

(B) 'are living'

(C) 'have lived'

(D) 'had lived'

Q187. [Compare the sentences] You look outside and see wet streets. Both sentences are correct. Explain the different picture each one gives. (1) 'It has been raining.' (2) 'It has rained.'

Q188. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'I met her in 2010. Until then, I ___ anyone from that country.'

(A) 'didn't meet'
(B) 'hadn't met'
(C) 'haven't met'
(D) 'don't meet'

Q189. [Choose the context] You want to describe a habit that annoyed you in the past but has now stopped. Which sentence fits best?

(A) 'He is always interrupting me.'
(B) 'He was always interrupting me.'
(C) 'He always interrupts me.'
(D) 'He has always interrupted me.'

Q190. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'The moment the clock ___ midnight, the fireworks will begin.'

(A) 'will strike'
(B) 'strikes'
(C) 'will have struck'
(D) 'is striking'

Q191. [Correct the sentence] Correct the one tense error in this sentence: 'By the time the ambulance arrived, the patient already stopped breathing, but the paramedics revived him.'

Q192. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'She ___ five cups of coffee today, and she still feels sleepy.'

(A) 'has been drinking'
(B) 'has drunk'
(C) 'drinks'
(D) 'is drinking'

Q193. [Ambiguity analysis] The sentence 'When I got to the station, the train left.' is grammatically correct but can mislead. Explain the two possible interpretations, and show how the past perfect could

remove any confusion.

Q194. [Choose ALL correct answers] Select ALL the sentences that are correct.

(A) 'I have finished my homework, so I can play now.'
(B) 'I have finished my homework an hour ago.'
(C) 'Have you ever eaten sushi?'
(D) 'She has already left.'
(E) 'Columbus has discovered America.'

Q195. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'He promised he ___ me, but he never did.'

(A) 'will call'
(B) 'would call'
(C) 'calls'
(D) 'had called'

Q196. [Which is better?] You have spent all day painting a fence; you are tired and covered in paint, and the job is now done. A friend asks what you have been up to. Which reply is more natural, and why? (1) 'I've painted the fence.' (2) 'I've been painting the fence.'

Q197. [Multiple choice] Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'When the coach finally arrived, the players ___ for two hours and were exhausted.'

(A) 'had practised'
(B) 'had been practising'
(C) 'were practising'
(D) 'practised'

Q198. [Choose the context] You are describing an appointment you have already arranged with the dentist for next Tuesday. Which sentence is the most natural?

(A) 'I will see the dentist on Tuesday.'
(B) 'I am seeing the dentist on Tuesday.'
(C) 'I see the dentist on Tuesday.'
(D) 'I will be seeing the dentist on Tuesday.'

Q199. [Compare the sentences] Explain the difference in meaning between these three correct sentences. (1) 'I lived in Rome for three years.' (2) 'I have lived in Rome for three years.' (3) 'I had lived in Rome for three years before I moved to Milan.'

Q200. [Short writing] In three or four sentences, describe your day yesterday, from waking up to going to bed. Use at least one simple past, one past continuous, and one past perfect correctly, and label each of the three (write the tense name in brackets after the verb).

Answer Key and Reasoning

This section is for review **after** the whole paper is finished. For each question you will find the correct answer, a full explanation, an analysis of every wrong option and the misconception it reveals, the underlying grammar principle, a memorable intuition to lock it in, a difficulty rating out of 10, and the cognitive skill being tested. Read the explanations even for questions you answered correctly; the reasoning is the real lesson.

Section 0 — Warm-Up: Core Tense Recognition

Q1. (Multiple choice) Every morning, my grandfather ____ a long walk in the park.

Correct answer: (A) takes

Why: 'Every morning' marks a repeated habit, and habits use the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'is taking' is present continuous, which means right now, not every day. Misconception: treating the continuous as an all-purpose present.
- **(C)** 'took' is simple past, a single finished event, not a repeated routine. Misconception: ignoring the habitual marker.
- **(D)** 'has taken' is present perfect and needs present relevance, not a daily habit. Misconception: reaching for the perfect without a reason.

Principle: Repeated or habitual actions take the simple present, often with adverbs like every day, usually, always.

Intuition hook: If it happens like clockwork, keep the verb plain and simple.

Difficulty: 2/10 | Cognitive skill: Recognising habit from adverbials

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Q2. (Fill in the blank) Fill the blank with the correct form of the verb in brackets. — Water ____ (boil) at 100 degrees Celsius at sea level.

Correct answer: boils

Why: A scientific fact that is always true takes the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

- 'is boiling' (continuous) wrongly suggests it is happening at this moment rather than always. Misconception: using the continuous for a permanent truth.
- 'boiled' (past) wrongly places a timeless fact in finished time. Misconception: attaching tense to a fact that has no time limit.

Principle: General truths and scientific facts use the simple present.

Intuition hook: Facts that are always true live in the plain present.

Difficulty: 2/10 | Cognitive skill: Distinguishing timeless fact from event

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Q3. (Multiple choice) Look! The baby ____ at you.

Correct answer: (B) is smiling

Why: 'Look!' points to an action happening at this very moment, so the present continuous is required.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'smiles' is a habit, not something happening now. Misconception: using simple present for an action in progress.

• **(C)** 'smiled' is finished past, but the baby is smiling right now. Misconception: mismatching the moment of speaking.

• **(D)** 'smile' does not agree with the singular subject and is not a finite present form here. Misconception: dropping the -s and the auxiliary.

Principle: Actions in progress at the moment of speaking use am/is/are + -ing.

Intuition hook: 'Look!' or 'Listen!' almost always means an -ing action is happening now.

Difficulty: 2/10 | Cognitive skill: Reading 'now' from the situation

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Q4. (Fill in the blank) Yesterday, our class ____ (visit) the science museum.

Correct answer: visited

Why: 'Yesterday' names a finished time, so the completed action takes the simple past.

Distractor analysis:

• 'have visited' (present perfect) clashes with a stated finished time; you cannot say 'have visited yesterday'. Misconception: using present perfect with a definite past time.

• 'was visiting' (past continuous) would need an interruption or background frame that is not here. Misconception: adding an -ing without a reason.

Principle: A completed action at a definite past time uses the simple past.

Intuition hook: A finished time word like 'yesterday' locks the verb into the simple past.

Difficulty: 1/10 | Cognitive skill: Matching finished time to simple past

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Q5. (Multiple choice) By the time we reached the hall, the concert ____.

Correct answer: (B) had already started

Why: Two past events are compared. The concert starting happened before we reached, so it takes the past perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'already started' drops the auxiliary 'had' that marks the earlier event. Misconception: forgetting the 'had' that signals 'first past'.

• **(C)** 'has already started' is present perfect and cannot sit before another past point. Misconception: mixing present perfect into a past timeline.

• **(D)** 'starts' is present and ignores that everything here is in the past. Misconception: losing track of the timeline entirely.

Principle: When two past events are compared, the earlier one takes the past perfect (had + past participle).

Intuition hook: The 'first past' event wears the 'had' badge.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Ordering two past events

Q6. (Fill in the blank) She ____ (live) in this city since 2019.

Correct answer: has lived

Why: 'Since 2019' marks a state that began in the past and still continues, so the present perfect is used.

Distractor analysis:

• 'lived' (simple past) would wrongly suggest she no longer lives there. Misconception: treating an ongoing state as finished.

• 'is living' alone cannot take 'since 2019' to mean the whole stretch up to now. Misconception: using a plain continuous where duration-to-now is meant.

Principle: A state or action beginning in the past and continuing to now uses the present perfect, especially with 'since'.

Intuition hook: 'Since' plus 'still true today' equals has/have + past participle.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Linking 'since' to continuing relevance

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Q7. (Multiple choice) 'You look worried. Don't panic — I ____ help you with your project.'

Correct answer: (C) will help

Why: The speaker decides to help at the moment of speaking, and a spontaneous offer or promise uses 'will'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'am helping' suggests a fixed prior arrangement, but this is a decision made on the spot. Misconception: confusing a plan with an offer.
- **(B)** 'help' is simple present and cannot express this future promise. Misconception: using present for a future decision.
- **(D)** 'helped' is past, but the help has not happened yet. Misconception: wrong direction in time.

Principle: Offers, promises, and decisions made at the moment of speaking use 'will'.

Intuition hook: A promise made on the spot rides on 'will'.

Difficulty: 2/10 | Cognitive skill: Spotting a spontaneous decision

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Q8. (Fill in the blank) Quiet, please! The students ____ (write) a test right now.

Correct answer: are writing

Why: 'Right now' marks an action in progress, so the present continuous is used.

Distractor analysis:

- 'write' (simple present) would mean a habit, not this moment. Misconception: using simple present for an ongoing action.
- 'wrote' (simple past) contradicts 'right now'. Misconception: mismatching the present moment.

Principle: Use the present continuous for an action happening at the moment of speaking.

Intuition hook: 'Right now' is a green light for -ing.

Difficulty: 1/10 | Cognitive skill: Matching 'now' to present continuous

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Q9. (Multiple choice) My mother ____ to work by metro every single day.

Correct answer: (B) goes

Why: 'Every single day' marks a habit, and habits use the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'is going' means now or a temporary phase, not a daily routine. Misconception: continuous used for a permanent habit.
- **(C)** 'has gone' suggests she has left and is away now, not a routine. Misconception: reading a habit as a present result.
- **(D)** 'went' is a single finished trip, not a repeated pattern. Misconception: past used for a habit.

Principle: Daily routines use the simple present.

Intuition hook: 'Every day' is the plain present's home turf.

Difficulty: 2/10 | Cognitive skill: Recognising routine

Q10. (Fill in the blank) The sun ____ (rise) in the east and ____ (set) in the west.

Correct answer: rises; sets

Why: These are permanent natural truths, so both verbs take the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

- 'is rising / is setting' would wrongly limit a permanent truth to this moment. Misconception: using continuous for a general truth.
- 'rose / set' would wrongly place a timeless fact in the past. Misconception: adding past time to an always-true statement.

Principle: Permanent, always-true statements use the simple present.

Intuition hook: If it was true yesterday and will be true tomorrow, use the plain present.

Difficulty: 1/10 | Cognitive skill: Timeless truth recognition

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Section A — Present Tense Nuance

Q11. (Multiple choice) I ____ the answer to this difficult question.

Correct answer: (B) know

Why: 'Know' is a stative verb (a state of mind), so it uses the simple present and normally rejects the -ing form.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'am knowing' forces a state into the continuous. Misconception: treating every present idea as an -ing action.
- **(C)** 'have been knowing' piles the continuous onto a stative verb. Misconception: over-applying the perfect continuous.
- **(D)** 'knows' does not agree with 'I'. Misconception: subject–verb mismatch.

Principle: Stative verbs (know, believe, own, understand) describe states, not actions, and normally avoid the continuous.

Intuition hook: You cannot be 'in the middle of knowing'. You simply know.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative-verb filtering

Q12. (Multiple choice) Read the two sentences. (1) 'My cousin is staying with us this week.' (2) 'My cousin stays with us.' Which sentence shows a temporary, short-term visit?

Correct answer: (A) Sentence 1

Why: The present continuous ('is staying') with 'this week' marks a temporary situation; the simple present ('stays') states a general or repeated fact.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'stays' describes a habit or permanent arrangement, not a one-week visit. Misconception: reading the simple present as temporary.
- **(C)** The two forms carry different meanings, so they are not equal. Misconception: assuming the tenses are interchangeable.
- **(D)** Sentence 1 clearly signals temporariness. Misconception: missing the temporary marker.

Principle: Present continuous = temporary; simple present = permanent or habitual.

Intuition hook: '-ing' for the short term; plain present for the long term.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Temporary vs. permanent

Q13. (Fill in the blank) We ____ (be) close friends since primary school.

Correct answer: have been

Why: 'Since primary school' marks a state that began in the past and continues to now, so use the present perfect.

Distractor analysis:

- 'are friends since' is a very common error; the simple present cannot express a stretch of time up to now. Misconception: using the present simple with 'since'.
- 'were friends' would suggest the friendship has ended. Misconception: treating an ongoing state as finished.

Principle: A state continuing from the past up to now uses the present perfect, especially with 'since' or 'for'.

Intuition hook: 'Since' + still true today = have/has been.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Duration-to-now with a stative verb

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Q14. (Correct the sentence) Rewrite this sentence correctly: 'I am not understanding this chapter at all.'

Correct answer: I do not understand this chapter at all.

Why: 'Understand' is a stative verb of mental state, so it takes the simple present, not the continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'am not understanding' forces a state into the -ing form. Misconception: applying the continuous to a verb of mental state.

Principle: Verbs of thinking and perceiving (understand, know, realise) are usually stative and avoid the continuous.

Intuition hook: Understanding is a state you are in, not an action you perform.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Correcting a stative-continuous error

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Q15. (Multiple choice) 'Where is Meera?' 'She ____ to the dentist — she will be back by five.'

Correct answer: (A) has gone

Why: 'Has gone to' means she went and is still there (not back yet), which fits 'she will be back by five'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** 'has been to' means she went and has already returned, which contradicts 'will be back by five'. Misconception: confusing 'have gone' (still away) with 'have been' (already returned).

• **(C)** 'is going' describes an action in progress or an arrangement, not where she is now. Misconception: mismatching the question 'where is she?'

• **(D)** 'goes' is a habit, not this single situation. Misconception: using the simple present for a one-time result.

Principle: 'Have gone (to)' = went and still there; 'have been (to)' = went and came back.

Intuition hook: Gone means still gone; been means back again.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Gone' vs. 'been' in the present perfect

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Q16. (Choose ALL correct answers) Which of these sentences are correct as written? Choose ALL that apply.

Correct answer: (A) and (D)

Why: Sentence A uses the present continuous for a genuinely temporary situation; sentence D uses it for a temporary change of routine. Both are correct.

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** 'own' is stative, so 'am owning' is wrong; it should be 'I own three bicycles'. Misconception: continuous with a possession verb.

• **(C)** The Earth orbiting the Sun is a permanent fact and needs the simple present ('goes'); 'is going' wrongly makes an eternal truth temporary. Misconception: continuous for a permanent scientific truth.

Principle: Use the present continuous only for temporary or in-progress situations, never for stative verbs or permanent facts.

Intuition hook: If it is always true or is a state, drop the -ing.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Filtering multiple present-tense uses at once

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Q17. (Explain the error) Explain why this sounds wrong in careful English, and give the corrected sentence: 'I am really liking this new song.'

Correct answer: 'Like' is a stative verb (a feeling), so standard English uses the simple present: 'I really like this new song.'

Why: Verbs of liking and feeling (like, love, hate, prefer) describe states and normally avoid the continuous. (Note: casual slogans such as 'I'm loving it' bend this rule for effect, but careful/standard English keeps the simple present.)

Distractor analysis:

• Accepting the -ing form treats a feeling as an ongoing action. Misconception: applying the continuous to a stative feeling verb.

Principle: Stative verbs of emotion take the simple present.

Intuition hook: Feelings are states you are in, so keep them plain and simple.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Detecting a stative-feeling error

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Q18. (Multiple choice) My eyes really hurt. I ____ at this screen for three hours without a break.

Correct answer: (A) have been staring

Why: The present perfect continuous stresses an activity that has continued up to now and explains a present result (sore eyes).

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** 'have stared' stresses completion or a count, not the ongoing three-hour activity that caused the pain. Misconception: using the plain present perfect where duration up to now is meant.

• **(C)** 'am staring' ignores the three-hour stretch leading up to now. Misconception: present continuous with no sense of duration.

• **(D)** 'stared' cuts the action off from the present, but the eyes hurt right now. Misconception: detaching a past-to-now action from the present.

Principle: Present perfect continuous = an action in progress from the past up to now, often explaining a present state.

Intuition hook: 'I have been -ing for [time]' explains why things are the way they are right now.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect continuous for duration

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Q19. (Fill in the blank) Normally I sleep very well, but these days I ____ (not / sleep) properly because of the exams.

Correct answer: am not sleeping

Why: The contrast with 'normally' plus 'these days ... because of the exams' marks a temporary situation, so use the present continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• 'do not sleep' (simple present) would wrongly claim this is a permanent habit, contradicting 'normally I sleep well'. Misconception: using the simple present for a temporary change.

Principle: A temporary change from one's usual habit uses the present continuous.

Intuition hook: 'These days' signals a passing phase, so reach for -ing.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Temporary vs. habitual contrast

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Q20. (Which is better?) Which sentence is correct for a bicycle you got as a child and still own today?

Correct answer: (A)

Why: A period of possession running from the past up to now uses the present perfect ('have had'), even though 'have' is a stative verb.

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** 'have ... since' with the simple present cannot express a span up to now; it should be 'have had'. Misconception: using the present simple of 'have' with 'since'.

Principle: Duration up to now uses the present perfect, even with stative verbs like 'have' (possess).

Intuition hook: For 'since / for + now', upgrade 'have' to 'have had'.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect with a stative verb

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Q21. (Multiple choice) 'You keep changing your answer! What ____ you actually ____?'
Correct answer: (A) do / believe
Why: 'Believe' is stative, so the present-tense question uses 'do you believe', not the continuous.
Distractor analysis:
- **(B)** 'are you believing' forces a stative verb into the continuous. Misconception: -ing with a mental-state verb.
- **(C)** 'have you believed' shifts the meaning to a completed idea. Misconception: swapping in the present perfect.
- **(D)** 'did you believe' points to the past, but the situation is happening now. Misconception: wrong time reference.

Principle: Stative verbs form present questions with do/does + base verb, not with the continuous.
Intuition hook: 'What do you believe?' – never 'What are you believing?'
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verbs in questions

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Q22. (Rewrite (keep the meaning)) Rewrite as ONE sentence using the present perfect continuous, keeping the meaning: 'Mr. Rao started coaching our team in January. He is still coaching us now.'
Correct answer: Mr. Rao has been coaching our team since January.
Why: An action that began in the past and continues now, with focus on the ongoing activity, uses the present perfect continuous with 'since'.
Distractor analysis:
- 'Mr. Rao is coaching since January' wrongly uses a plain continuous for a stretch up to now. Misconception: dropping the perfect from a since-phrase.
- 'Mr. Rao coaches since January' uses the simple present with 'since', which is incorrect. Misconception: present simple + since.

Principle: Present perfect continuous joins a past start to an ongoing present activity.
Intuition hook: Started then + still going now = has/have been -ing since.
Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Combining ideas into perfect continuous

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Q23. (Choose the context) For which situation is 'I have lived in Pune since 2020' the correct sentence (rather than 'I lived in Pune in 2020')?
Correct answer: (A)
Why: The present perfect with 'since' means the state started in the past and continues to the present.
Distractor analysis:
- **(B)** A finished stay needs the simple past, 'I lived in Pune in 2020'. Misconception: using the present perfect for a closed past period.
- **(C)** A future plan needs a future form, not the present perfect. Misconception: mapping the perfect onto the future.
- **(D)** A single finished visit uses the simple past. Misconception: perfect for a one-off past event.

Principle: Present perfect = past action or state with a continuing link to now.
Intuition hook: If it is still true today, choose 'have lived', not 'lived'.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Mapping tense to a real situation

---

Q24. (Multiple choice) The speaker is complaining about an irritating, repeated habit: 'He ____ his phone somewhere; it drives me crazy!'

Correct answer: (B) is always losing

Why: The present continuous with 'always' expresses a repeated action that annoys the speaker, adding an emotional colour that the neutral simple present does not.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'always loses' is a neutral statement of fact; it is grammatical, but it does not carry the complaining tone the context calls for. Misconception: missing that 'is always -ing' signals irritation.
- **(C)** 'has always lost' points to a completed record, not an ongoing irritation. Misconception: perfect for a live complaint.
- **(D)** 'lost' is a single past event. Misconception: past for a repeated habit.

Principle: Present continuous + always/constantly/forever expresses a repeated, often annoying, habit.

Intuition hook: 'He is always losing it' = the complaint version; 'he always loses it' = the neutral fact.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Continuous + 'always' for attitude

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Q25. (Fill in the blank) No tea for me, thanks. I ____ (prefer) coffee in the mornings.

Correct answer: prefer

Why: 'Prefer' is a stative verb of choice and feeling, so it uses the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

- 'am preferring' forces a stative verb into the continuous. Misconception: -ing with a preference verb.

Principle: Verbs of preference (prefer, want, need) are stative and take the simple present.

Intuition hook: Preferring is a settled state, so keep it plain.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb 'prefer'

Q26. (Are both acceptable?) Are both acceptable in standard English? (1) 'I have known Aisha for five years.' (2) 'I know Aisha for five years.'

Correct answer: (A) Only (1) is correct

Why: Duration up to now with the stative verb 'know' requires the present perfect: 'have known ... for five years'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'I know Aisha for five years' is a classic error; the simple present cannot carry 'for five years' up to now. Misconception: present simple + for-duration.
- **(C)** The two are not equal, since (2) is ungrammatical. Misconception: assuming both are fine.
- **(D)** Sentence (1) is correct, so 'neither' is wrong. Misconception: rejecting a correct present perfect.

Principle: 'For / since + up to now' with a stative verb still requires the present perfect.

Intuition hook: 'I have known her for years' – never 'I know her for years'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect vs. present simple with duration

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Q27. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'She has never wrote a poem before.'

Correct answer: She has never written a poem before.

Why: The present perfect needs the past participle 'written', not the simple past 'wrote'.

Distractor analysis:

- Keeping 'wrote' mixes the simple past into a present perfect frame. Misconception: using the past-tense form (wrote) where the participle (written) is required.

Principle: Present perfect = has/have + past participle. For irregular verbs, the participle differs from the simple past.

Intuition hook: After 'has/have', use the third column: write → wrote → written.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Participle form inside the present perfect

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Q28. (Multiple choice) Choose the correct sentence.

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'Last year' is a definite finished time, which requires the simple past.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** The present perfect cannot combine with a specific finished time like 'last year'. Misconception: 'have visited' + a dated past time.
- **(C)** The present continuous cannot take 'last year'. Misconception: -ing form with finished past time.
- **(D)** The simple present cannot describe a finished past event. Misconception: present for a past action.

Principle: A finished, dated past time requires the simple past, not the present perfect.

Intuition hook: If you can point to when (last year, in 2019), use the simple past.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect vs. simple past with a time marker

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Q29. (Explain the error) A tourist asks a shopkeeper, 'How long are you living in this town?' The shopkeeper looks confused. Explain the problem and give the correct question.

Correct answer: To ask about time up to now, use the present perfect: 'How long have you lived (or have you been living) in this town?'

Why: The present continuous 'are you living' suggests a temporary phase or the near future, not the whole span of time up to the present. Duration questions about now use the present perfect.

Distractor analysis:

- Keeping the present continuous asks about a temporary or future situation, not lifelong residence. Misconception: using the present continuous for duration up to now.

Principle: 'How long' questions about the present use have/has + past participle.

Intuition hook: For 'how long up to now', reach for 'have you ...ed', not 'are you ...ing'.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Duration questions with the present perfect

---

Q30. (Multiple choice) A live cricket commentator describes fast action: 'Sharma ____ the ball... and he ____ it straight to the boundary!' Which forms are typical of quick live commentary?

Correct answer: (B) bowls / hits

Why: Live commentary conventionally uses the simple present for rapid, complete-in-the-moment actions, as in 'he passes, he shoots, he scores'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** The present continuous suits longer background action ('Sharma is running in to bowl'), not the sharp, finished strike. Misconception: -ing for every live action.
- **(C)** The simple past would narrate the game after the fact, not as it happens. Misconception: past tense for live action.
- **(D)** The present perfect stresses result and relevance, not the quick sequence of live play. Misconception: perfect for live commentary.

Principle: Sports and event commentary uses the simple present for quick, sequential, completed actions.

Intuition hook: 'He shoots, he scores' – commentary lives in the plain present.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple present in commentary

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Q31. (Fill in the blank) Please do not disturb her. She ____ (talk) to the principal at the moment.

Correct answer: is talking

Why: 'At the moment' marks an action in progress, so use the present continuous.

Distractor analysis:

- 'talks' (simple present) would mean a habit, not this moment. Misconception: simple present for an action happening now.

Principle: Present continuous for an action in progress at the moment of speaking.

Intuition hook: 'At the moment' points straight at -ing.

Difficulty: 2/10 | Cognitive skill: 'At the moment' recognition

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Q32. (Multiple choice) In which sentence is the -ing form correct?

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'Think about (= consider)' is a dynamic mental process and takes the continuous; understand, know, and want are stative and reject the -ing form.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'understand' is stative; use 'I understand the lesson now'. Misconception: continuous with a state of understanding.
- **(C)** 'know' is stative; use 'I know the answer'. Misconception: continuous with a knowledge verb.
- **(D)** 'want' is stative; use 'I want a short break'. Misconception: continuous with a desire verb.

Principle: A verb can be dynamic (an action, e.g. thinking = considering) or stative (a state); only dynamic uses take the continuous.

Intuition hook: 'Thinking about' is doing something in your head; 'knowing / wanting / understanding' are just states.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Dynamic vs. stative senses of verbs

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Q33. (Choose the context) In which situation is 'Ravi is working at a bank' the better choice (rather than 'Ravi works at a bank')?

Correct answer: (B)

Why: The present continuous marks a temporary job; the simple present marks a permanent one.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** A permanent profession uses the simple present, 'Ravi works at a bank'. Misconception: continuous for a permanent job.
- **(C)** A settled career choice is a general fact, so use the simple present. Misconception: continuous for a stable fact.
- **(D)** If he no longer works, the present continuous is simply false. Misconception: present continuous for something not happening.

Principle: Present continuous = temporary situation; simple present = permanent situation.

Intuition hook: Summer job now = 'is working'; life-long career = 'works'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Temporary vs. permanent employment

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Q34. (Multiple choice) 'Do not offer him lunch — he ____ eaten.' (He ate a few minutes ago and is still full.)

Correct answer: (B) has just

Why: 'Has just eaten' is the present perfect with 'just', used for a very recent action that has a present result (he is full now). The order is has + just + past participle.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'just has eaten' puts the adverb in the wrong place for standard English. Misconception: mis-ordering the adverb 'just'.
- **(C)** 'he just eaten' drops the auxiliary 'has'. Misconception: leaving out the auxiliary of the present perfect.
- **(D)** 'is just eaten' uses the wrong auxiliary and makes a passive-looking form. Misconception: confusing the auxiliary 'has' with 'is'.

Principle: Present perfect with 'just' = a recently completed action with a present result; word order is has/have + just + past participle.

Intuition hook: 'He has just eaten' = it happened moments ago and still matters now.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect with 'just' and word order

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Section B — Past Tense Nuance

Q35. (Multiple choice) I ____ TV peacefully when the lights suddenly ____ out.
Correct answer: (B) was watching / went
Why: The longer background action in progress uses the past continuous ('was watching'); the sudden, short interruption uses the simple past ('went out').
Distractor analysis:
- **(A)** 'watched ... when' loses the 'in the middle of' meaning; it reads as a sequence, not an interruption. Misconception: using the simple past for a background action.
- **(C)** 'were going out' turns a sudden single event into an ongoing one. Misconception: continuous for a quick, completed interruption.
- **(D)** This reverses both forms. Misconception: swapping background and interruption.

Principle: Background action = past continuous; the event that interrupts it = simple past.
Intuition hook: The long thing was in progress (-ing) when the short thing struck (plain past).
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Interrupted past action

Q36. (Fill in the blank) When we finally reached the platform, the train ____ (already / leave).
Correct answer: had already left
Why: The train leaving happened before we reached the platform, and 'already' confirms the earlier completion, so use the past perfect.
Distractor analysis:
- 'already left' drops the auxiliary 'had' that marks the earlier past event. Misconception: forgetting 'had' before an earlier action.
- 'has already left' is present perfect and cannot sit inside a past-time story. Misconception: mixing present perfect into a past narrative.

Principle: Of two past events, the earlier one takes the past perfect (had + past participle), especially with 'already'.
Intuition hook: The action that finished first wears the 'had' badge.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect for the earlier event

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Q37. (Which is better?) Which sentence is more natural?
Correct answer: (B)
Why: When events are told in the order they happened and joined by 'then', the simple past is enough; the past perfect is unnecessary.
Distractor analysis:
- **(A)** 'had gone' wrongly marks the second, later action as the earlier one, which is backwards and needless. Misconception: over-using the past perfect for a plain sequence.

Principle: Use the past perfect only to signal that one past event came before another; a straightforward 'first... then' sequence needs only the simple past.
Intuition hook: Do not sprinkle 'had' everywhere; save it for the event that truly came first.
Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Avoiding past-perfect overuse

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Q38. (Correct the sentence) Correct the tense error: 'While she was reading, the lights suddenly went out and she was dropping her book.'

Correct answer: While she was reading, the lights suddenly went out and she dropped her book.

Why: Dropping the book is a single, sudden, completed action, so it takes the simple past ('dropped'); only the ongoing background ('was reading') is continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'was dropping' turns an instant action into an ongoing one. Misconception: continuous for a sudden, one-moment action.

Principle: Sudden, completed actions use the simple past; only genuinely ongoing background actions use the past continuous.

Intuition hook: A book drops in an instant, so it cannot be 'in progress'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Correcting a continuous-for-sudden error

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Q39. (Multiple choice) I didn't recognise the town at all. It ____ a lot since my last visit.

Correct answer: (B) had changed

Why: The story is set in the past ('I didn't recognise'), and the changing happened before that past moment, so 'since' here requires the past perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'changed ... since' is incorrect; 'since' does not pair with the plain simple past. Misconception: simple past with 'since'.

• **(C)** 'was changing' describes an action in progress, not the completed change up to that past point. Misconception: continuous for a completed change.

• **(D)** 'has changed' is present perfect and clashes with the past setting 'I didn't recognise'. Misconception: present perfect inside a past narrative.

Principle: Inside a past-tense narrative, 'since' takes the past perfect, not the present perfect or simple past.

Intuition hook: Past story + 'since' = had + past participle.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect with 'since' in past narration

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Q40. (Multiple choice) By the time the guests finally left, we ____ for six straight hours, and the kitchen was a total mess.

Correct answer: (A) had been cooking

Why: 'By the time (past)' needs the past perfect, and 'for six straight hours' points to an ongoing activity, so the past perfect continuous fits both.

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** 'cooked' has no auxiliary to mark 'before that past point', which 'by the time' demands. Misconception: simple past after 'by the time'.

• **(C)** 'were cooking' lacks the past perfect needed before the guests left. Misconception: past continuous with no 'had'.

• **(D)** 'have been cooking' is present perfect continuous and clashes with the past setting. Misconception: present perfect in a past story.

Principle: Past perfect continuous = an ongoing activity that continued up to a point in the past, often after 'by the time'.

Intuition hook: 'By the time' + how long + still going = had been -ing.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect continuous for duration before a past point

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Q41. (Fill in the blank) By the time the ambulance arrived, the injured man ____ (already / lose) a great deal of blood.

Correct answer: had already lost

Why: The blood loss was complete before the ambulance arrived, and 'by the time' plus 'already' confirms the earlier completion, so use the past perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• 'already lost' omits 'had', the marker of the earlier past event. Misconception: dropping the auxiliary of the past perfect.

• 'has already lost' is present perfect and does not belong in a past-time story. Misconception: present perfect in past narration.

Principle: 'By the time (past), ... had already (done)' places the completed action before the later past point.

Intuition hook: Finished before the next past event? Use 'had'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect after 'by the time'

Q42. (Explain the error) A student wants to say that he ate dinner AFTER getting home. He writes: 'When I reached home, I had eaten dinner.' Explain why this does not say what he means, and give the correct sentence.

Correct answer: 'Had eaten' means the dinner was already finished before he reached home. To mean he ate after arriving, use the simple past: 'When I reached home, I ate dinner.'

Why: The past perfect always signals the earlier of two past events, so 'had eaten' puts the dinner before the arrival, the opposite of his intended order.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping the past perfect reverses the true sequence of events. Misconception: thinking 'had' just makes a verb 'more past' rather than marking which event came first.

Principle: The past perfect marks the earlier of two past events; it changes the meaning, not just the 'feel'.

Intuition hook: 'Had done' = done before the other past thing, so check the order before you use it.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Meaning control with the past perfect

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Q43. (Order the events) Based on this sentence, write the three events in the order they actually happened (earliest first): 'When the manager walked in, the team had submitted the report and were celebrating quietly.'

Correct answer: 1) The team submitted the report. 2) The manager walked in (while) 3) the team was celebrating.

Why: 'Had submitted' (past perfect) is the earliest event; 'walked in' (simple past) is the reference point; 'were celebrating' (past continuous) was in progress at that reference point.

Distractor analysis:

• Reading the sentence in written order (walked in first) misses that 'had submitted' happened earliest. Misconception: assuming events are always narrated in time order.

Principle: Past perfect = earliest; simple past = the reference point; past continuous = in progress at that point.

Intuition hook: 'Had' comes first in time, even if it comes second in the sentence.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Reconstructing event order from tense

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Q44. (Fill in the blank) When the teacher walked in, the students ____ (talk) so loudly that they did not even notice her.

Correct answer: were talking

Why: The talking was already in progress when the teacher entered, which the past continuous captures; the added clause 'did not even notice her' confirms it was ongoing.

Distractor analysis:

• 'talked' would read as if they started talking the moment she entered, contradicting 'did not even notice her'. Misconception: using the simple past for an action that was already in progress.

Principle: An action already in progress at a past moment uses the past continuous.

Intuition hook: They were mid-chatter when she walked in, so use '-ing'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Past continuous for an action in progress

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Q45. (Spot the error) One verb uses the past perfect where it is not needed. Find it and give the corrected verb: 'Yesterday morning I had finished my breakfast and rushed straight to school.'

Correct answer: 'had finished' should be 'finished'.

Why: This is a simple two-step sequence in the order it happened; the past perfect is unnecessary, so the simple past 'finished' is correct.

Distractor analysis:

• Leaving 'had finished' over-marks a plain sequence as if it needed to be set before another event. Misconception: using the past perfect whenever two past actions appear together.

Principle: The past perfect is only needed to show that one past event clearly preceded another; a plain 'and then' sequence does not require it.

Intuition hook: Two actions in a row are not automatically 'had'; keep it simple unless order needs marking.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Detecting unnecessary past perfect

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Q46. (Choose ALL correct answers) In which sentences is the past perfect used correctly and usefully? Choose ALL that apply.

Correct answer: (A) and (C)

Why: In A the burning finished before the firefighters arrived, and in C the forgetting happened before the realising; both correctly use the past perfect for the earlier event.

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** This is a simple sequence, so every 'had' is over-used; it should be plain simple past. Misconception: past perfect for an ordinary chain of events.

• **(D)** A single past event with a time reference needs the simple past ('I went to the market yesterday'). Misconception: past perfect for a lone past action.

Principle: Use the past perfect only for an event that clearly happened before another past event or reference point.

Intuition hook: One earlier event behind a later one = 'had'; a plain list of steps = simple past.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Judging when the past perfect is justified

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Q47. (Fill in the blank) Describe the scene that was already happening as we set off. The sun ____ (shine) brightly and the birds ____ (sing) in the trees when we left the house.

Correct answer: was shining; were singing

Why: These describe background conditions already in progress at the past moment we left, so both take the past continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• 'shone / sang' would suggest the shining and singing began the moment we left, rather than being already underway. Misconception: simple past for ongoing background scenery.

Principle: Ongoing background description at a past point uses the past continuous.

Intuition hook: Scene-setting that is already underway wants '-ing'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Past continuous for background scene

---

Q48. (Multiple choice) The moment the final bell rang, the students ____ their books and ____ the classroom.

Correct answer: (A) closed / left

Why: These are quick, completed actions that happened as a reaction to the bell, so the simple past is correct.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** The past continuous would mean they were only partway through when the bell rang, which is not the meaning. Misconception: continuous for finished reactions.
- **(C)** The past perfect wrongly places these actions before the bell rang. Misconception: past perfect for events that follow, not precede.
- **(D)** The simple present cannot narrate a past event. Misconception: present tense for a past action.

Principle: A quick, completed reaction to a past trigger uses the simple past.

Intuition hook: Bell rings, then they act and finish, so plain past for the actions.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past for a completed reaction

---

Q49. (Timeline reasoning) 'When the coach entered, the players had hidden the birthday cake and were pretending to stretch.' Which event happened FIRST?

Correct answer: (A) The players hid the cake

Why: 'Had hidden' (past perfect) is the earliest event; the coach entered afterwards, and the pretending was in progress at that moment.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** The coach entered after the cake was already hidden. Misconception: reading the first-mentioned clause as the first event.
- **(C)** The pretending was ongoing when the coach entered, so it did not start before the hiding. Misconception: treating the past continuous as the earliest event.
- **(D)** The past perfect specifically marks the hiding as earlier, so they were not simultaneous. Misconception: ignoring the ordering that tense provides.

Principle: The past perfect marks the earliest event, regardless of the order of mention.

Intuition hook: Find the 'had' and you have found what happened first.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Timeline reading from tense

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Q50. (Compare the sentences) Which sentence means the man was already gone before I got there? (1) 'When I arrived, he left.' (2) 'When I arrived, he had left.'

Correct answer: (B) Sentence 2

Why: 'Had left' places his leaving before my arrival; in sentence 1, 'left' suggests he left at or just after the moment I arrived.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** In sentence 1 the leaving lines up with or follows the arrival, not before it. Misconception: reading simple past as 'already earlier'.
- **(C)** The two sentences describe different orders of events. Misconception: assuming tense does not change the timeline.
- **(D)** Sentence 2 clearly gives the 'already gone' meaning. Misconception: overlooking the role of 'had'.

Principle: Past perfect vs. simple past after 'when' changes which event came first.

Intuition hook: 'He had left' = gone before you; 'he left' = went as/after you came.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Meaning contrast: past perfect vs. simple past

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Q51. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'I was knowing the answer, so I raised my hand.'

Correct answer: I knew the answer, so I raised my hand.

Why: 'Know' is a stative verb, so even in the past it uses the simple past ('knew'), not the past continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'was knowing' forces a state into the continuous. Misconception: stative verbs can take '-ing' in the past.

Principle: Stative verbs avoid the continuous in every tense, including the past.

Intuition hook: You cannot be 'in the middle of knowing', past or present.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verbs in the past

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Q52. (Fill in the blank) Before the internet ____ (become) common, people ____ (use) handwritten letters to keep in touch.

Correct answer: became; used

Why: Both refer to a general past time; with 'before' the order is already clear, so the simple past is enough for both verbs.

Distractor analysis:

• 'had become / had used' would over-mark a plain past-time description, since 'before' already shows the order. Misconception: adding the past perfect when a conjunction already orders events.

Principle: When 'before' or 'after' already shows the sequence, the simple past is usually sufficient.

Intuition hook: 'Before' does the ordering, so the verbs can stay simple.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past with an ordering conjunction

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Q53. (Multiple choice) When I was little, I ____ afraid of the dark, but I am not any more.

Correct answer: (A) was

Why: This is a past state that is no longer true, so the simple past 'was' is correct.

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** 'am' contradicts 'when I was little' and 'not any more'. Misconception: present tense for a finished past state.

• **(C)** 'have been' suggests the fear continues to now, but it has ended. Misconception: present perfect for a state that has stopped.

• **(D)** 'was being' would imply deliberate temporary behaviour, not a genuine past state of fear. Misconception: continuous for a stative feeling.

Principle: A past state that no longer holds uses the simple past.

Intuition hook: Over and done with? Plain past.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past for a former state

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Q54. (Explain the error) Explain the difference in meaning between these two sentences: (1) 'When the film started, we ate our popcorn.' (2) 'When the film started, we had eaten our popcorn.'

Correct answer: In (1) we ate the popcorn during or after the film started. In (2) 'had eaten' means the popcorn was already finished before the film started.

Why: The past perfect in (2) places the eating before the film began; the simple past in (1) lines the eating up with or after the start.

Distractor analysis:

• Treating the two as identical ignores what 'had' does to the order. Misconception: assuming the past perfect is just a stylistic variant.

Principle: Past perfect vs. simple past controls whether an action finished before or happened during another past event.

Intuition hook: 'Had eaten' = popcorn gone before the film; 'ate' = popcorn during the film.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Interpreting tense-driven meaning

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Q55. (Rewrite (keep the meaning)) Combine into ONE sentence using the past perfect, keeping the meaning: 'The train left. Then we reached the platform.'

Correct answer: When we reached the platform, the train had already left.

Why: The leaving happened first, so it takes the past perfect ('had left'); the later arrival takes the simple past.

Distractor analysis:

- 'When we reached the platform, the train left' would wrongly suggest it left as we arrived. Misconception: using the simple past for the clearly earlier event.

Principle: The earlier of two combined past events takes the past perfect.

Intuition hook: Gone before you arrived = 'had left'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Building a past-perfect sentence

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Q56. (Fill in the blank) The players were completely exhausted. They ____ (train — use the form that stresses the ongoing activity that caused it) hard for three hours before the coach let them rest.

Correct answer: had been training

Why: An activity that continued for a stretch of time and led up to a past result (their exhaustion) uses the past perfect continuous.

Distractor analysis:

- 'trained' states a completed fact but does not stress the ongoing activity behind the exhaustion. Misconception: missing that the past perfect continuous best explains a past state.
- 'were training' lacks the 'had', so it does not sit clearly before the coach's decision. Misconception: past continuous with no earlier-time marking.

Principle: Past perfect continuous shows a continuous activity leading up to, and explaining, a later past situation.

Intuition hook: Tired then, because they had been -ing for hours.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect continuous for a past cause

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Q57. (Multiple choice) Which option keeps the narrative consistent? 'Yesterday was strange. I woke up late, I ____ breakfast, and I ____ for the bus, but it never came.'

Correct answer: (B) skipped / waited

Why: The passage is a chain of completed past actions, so all verbs should stay in the simple past to match 'woke up' and 'came'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** The simple present breaks the past-tense narrative. Misconception: shifting into the present mid-story.
- **(C)** The past perfect wrongly signals these events came before the others, disrupting the sequence. Misconception: past perfect for a plain sequence.
- **(D)** The past continuous suggests these actions were merely in progress, not completed steps. Misconception: continuous for finished narrative actions.

Principle: A narrative of completed past events keeps a consistent simple past.

Intuition hook: Match the tense of the verbs around it; do not switch lanes mid-story.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Narrative tense consistency

---

Q58. (Spot the error) Find the ONE verb that breaks the past-tense narrative and give the correction: 'The storm hit at midnight. Trees fell, the power went out, and everyone rushes to shut the windows.'

Correct answer: 'rushes' should be 'rushed'.

Why: The whole passage is in the simple past ('hit', 'fell', 'went'), so 'rushes' is an inconsistent shift into the present and must become 'rushed'.

Distractor analysis:

• Leaving 'rushes' mixes present and past in one narrative. Misconception: losing tense control across a passage.

Principle: Keep one consistent tense throughout a narrative unless the meaning requires a shift.

Intuition hook: One present-tense verb in a past story sticks out; make it match.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Spotting a tense shift in a passage

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Section C — Future Tense Nuance

Q59. (Multiple choice) 'The phone is ringing.' 'Oh, I ____ answer it.'

Correct answer: (A) will

Why: The speaker decides to answer at the moment of speaking, and a spontaneous decision uses 'will'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** 'am going to' signals a decision made earlier, but this choice is made right now. Misconception: confusing a plan with a spur-of-the-moment decision.

• **(C)** 'am answering' suggests a fixed prior arrangement, which a ringing phone is not. Misconception: present continuous for an instant decision.

• **(D)** 'answer' is the simple present and cannot express this future action. Misconception: present tense for a future decision.

Principle: A decision made at the moment of speaking uses 'will'.

Intuition hook: Decide on the spot? Say 'I will'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Spontaneous decision

Q60. (Multiple choice) You can see it in the sky right now — those heavy dark clouds mean it ____ rain very soon.

Correct answer: (B) is going to

Why: When a prediction is based on present evidence you can see now, 'going to' is the natural choice.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will' makes a prediction too, but 'going to' is preferred when there is visible present evidence for it. Misconception: ignoring that visible evidence points to 'going to'.

• **(C)** 'rains' is the simple present for habits or schedules, not a prediction. Misconception: present simple for a forecast.

• **(D)** 'is raining' means it is raining now, but it has not started yet. Misconception: present continuous for something not yet happening.

Principle: A prediction based on present evidence uses 'be going to'.

Intuition hook: If you can see it coming, it is 'going to' happen.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Evidence-based prediction

---

Q61. (Fill in the blank) Hurry up! According to the timetable, the train ____ (leave) at exactly 7:15.

Correct answer: leaves

Why: Fixed timetables and schedules use the simple present, even for future events.

Distractor analysis:

• 'is leaving' suits a personal arrangement, but a public timetable uses the simple present. Misconception: continuous for a scheduled service.

• 'will leave' is a general prediction, not the fixed schedule the timetable states. Misconception: 'will' for a timetabled event.

Principle: Timetables and schedules use the simple present for future events.

Intuition hook: If a timetable prints it, use the plain present: 'the train leaves at...'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple present for schedules

---

Q62. (Multiple choice) I can't meet you on Friday afternoon. I ____ my dentist at 4 p.m. — the appointment is already booked.

Correct answer: (B) am seeing

Why: A fixed personal arrangement with a set time and place uses the present continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will see' suggests a decision made now, not an appointment already booked. Misconception: 'will' for a pre-arranged plan.

• **(C)** 'see' is the simple present for habits, not this single future appointment. Misconception: present simple for a one-time arrangement.

• **(D)** 'will be seeing' (future continuous) over-complicates a simple booked appointment. Misconception: future continuous for a plain arrangement.

Principle: Fixed future arrangements (with a time/place agreed) use the present continuous.

Intuition hook: Already booked with a time? Use 'I am -ing'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Present continuous for arrangements

---

Q63. (Multiple choice) By this time next year, I ____ from secondary school.

Correct answer: (B) will have graduated

Why: 'By (a future time)' with an action completed before that point uses the future perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will graduate' states a future action but does not stress that it is finished by that point. Misconception: simple future where completion-by-a-deadline is meant.

• **(C)** 'am graduating' is a present arrangement, not a completion by a future deadline. Misconception: present continuous for a future-perfect idea.

• **(D)** 'graduate' is the simple present and cannot express this. Misconception: present tense for a future completion.

Principle: Future perfect (will have + past participle) = an action completed before a future point.

Intuition hook: 'By [future time]' + already done = will have done.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Future perfect for completion by a deadline

---

Q64. (Fill in the blank) Don't worry about the money. I ____ (pay) you back next week, I promise.

Correct answer: will pay

Why: A promise uses 'will'.

Distractor analysis:

• 'am going to pay' states an intention, but 'I promise' calls for the promise form 'will'. Misconception: 'going to' for a solemn promise.

• 'pay' is the simple present and cannot carry this future promise. Misconception: present tense for a promise.

Principle: Promises use 'will'.

Intuition hook: 'I promise' pairs naturally with 'I will'.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Will' for a promise

Q65. (Multiple choice) Please don't call me at 8 tonight — I'll be right in the middle of it. I ____ dinner then.

Correct answer: (B) will be having

Why: The future continuous describes an action that will be in progress at a specific future time.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'will have' (future perfect/possession) does not express an action in progress. Misconception: mixing up future perfect and future continuous.
- **(C)** 'have' is the simple present, wrong for a future moment in progress. Misconception: present tense for a future ongoing action.
- **(D)** 'had' is the simple past, the wrong direction in time. Misconception: past for a future action.

Principle: Future continuous (will be + -ing) = an action in progress at a point in the future.

Intuition hook: 'At 8 I'll be mid-action' = will be -ing.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Future continuous for an in-progress future action

---

Q66. (Multiple choice) I've finally made up my mind. I ____ learn to play the guitar this year.

Correct answer: (B) am going to

Why: A decision already made (an intention) uses 'be going to', which 'I've finally made up my mind' signals.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'will' fits a decision made at the moment of speaking, but this decision is already made. Misconception: 'will' for a pre-formed intention.
- **(C)** 'learn' is the simple present and cannot express this plan. Misconception: present tense for an intention.
- **(D)** 'am learning' suggests a fixed arrangement already in progress, not a fresh intention. Misconception: present continuous for a plan with no fixed details.

Principle: 'Be going to' expresses an intention or a decision already made before speaking.

Intuition hook: Already decided in your head? 'I'm going to'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Going to' for prior intention

---

Q67. (Fill in the blank) The city museum ____ (open) at 9 a.m. and ____ (close) at 6 p.m. every day of the week.

Correct answer: opens; closes

Why: Regular opening hours are a fixed schedule, so both verbs use the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

- 'is opening / is closing' would wrongly make a permanent schedule sound temporary. Misconception: continuous for regular hours.
- 'will open / will close' treats a fixed timetable as a one-off prediction. Misconception: 'will' for scheduled hours.

Principle: Regular schedules and opening hours use the simple present.

Intuition hook: Opening hours are routine, so keep them in the plain present.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple present for a fixed schedule

---

Q68. (Compare the sentences) Which sentence describes a plan that is already arranged for a definite time? (1) 'I am visiting my grandmother this weekend.' (2) 'I will visit my grandmother someday.'

Correct answer: (A) Sentence 1

Why: The present continuous ('am visiting') with 'this weekend' marks a definite, arranged plan; 'will ... someday' is a vague, unarranged intention.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'will ... someday' has no fixed time and no arrangement. Misconception: reading 'will' as a firm plan.
- **(C)** The two express different degrees of certainty and arrangement. Misconception: treating the futures as equal.
- **(D)** Sentence 1 clearly describes an arranged plan. Misconception: missing the arrangement in the present continuous.

Principle: Present continuous = arranged, definite future plan; 'will' can be a vague or spontaneous future.

Intuition hook: A plan on the calendar is 'I am -ing'; a maybe-one-day is 'I will'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Arranged plan vs. vague future

---

Q69. (Multiple choice) The film starts at 8 p.m. and runs for two hours, so by 10:30 it ____.

Correct answer: (B) will have ended

Why: 'By 10:30' with an action finished before that point uses the future perfect.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'will end' does not stress that it is already over by 10:30. Misconception: simple future for a by-then completion.
- **(C)** 'ends' is the simple present, wrong for this completion. Misconception: present tense for a future-perfect meaning.
- **(D)** 'is ending' means ending right now, not finished by a future time. Misconception: present continuous for a future completion.

Principle: Future perfect = completed before a stated future time.

Intuition hook: 'By [future time], it will already be done' = will have + participle.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Future perfect with a deadline

---

Q70. (Correct the sentence) Correct the future form: 'Look out! You will drop the vase!' (You can see it is about to slip from his hands.)

Correct answer: Look out! You are going to drop the vase!

Why: When something is clearly about to happen, judged from what you can see right now, use 'be going to', not 'will'.

Distractor analysis:

- 'will drop' sounds like a general prediction rather than an imminent event based on present evidence. Misconception: 'will' for something visibly about to occur.

Principle: An imminent event, judged from present evidence, uses 'be going to'.

Intuition hook: About to happen before your eyes = 'going to'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Going to' for imminent events

---

Q71. (Multiple choice) According to the official timetable, our final exam ____ next Monday at 10 a.m.

Correct answer: (A) is

Why: A fixed, scheduled event can be stated with the simple present of 'to be'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'is being' is not used for a scheduled event like this. Misconception: continuous of 'be' for a timetabled event.
- **(C)** 'will be being' is not a natural English form here. Misconception: over-building the verb phrase.
- **(D)** 'was' is past, but the exam is in the future. Misconception: past tense for a future schedule.

Principle: Scheduled events can be expressed with the simple present ('The exam is on Monday').

Intuition hook: Fixed on the schedule? 'The exam is on Monday' works fine.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple present for a scheduled event

---

Q72. (Fill in the blank) Many scientists believe that robots ____ (do) most dangerous jobs in the future.

Correct answer: will do

Why: A general prediction about the future uses 'will'.

Distractor analysis:

- 'are doing' is present continuous and cannot express a future prediction. Misconception: present continuous for a general forecast.
- 'do' is the simple present for habits, not a prediction. Misconception: present tense for the future.

Principle: General predictions about the future use 'will'.

Intuition hook: A forecast with no present evidence leans on 'will'.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Will' for a general prediction

---

Q73. (Multiple choice) A: 'We've run out of milk.' B: 'Oh, ____ some on my way home.'

Correct answer: (A) I'll buy

Why: Speaker B reacts to information just heard and decides on the spot, so 'will' is correct.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'I'm going to buy' suggests a plan made earlier, but this is a fresh reaction to new information. Misconception: 'going to' for a spur-of-the-moment reaction.
- **(C)** 'I buy' is the simple present for habits, not this decision. Misconception: present tense for an instant decision.
- **(D)** 'I'm buying' implies an existing arrangement, which there is none. Misconception: present continuous for an on-the-spot choice.

Principle: A decision made in reaction to what you just heard uses 'will'.

Intuition hook: Just found out and decided right then? 'I'll'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Spontaneous reaction

Q74. (Multiple choice) We ____ our new neighbours to dinner on Saturday; the table is booked and everything is arranged.

Correct answer: (B) are inviting

Why: A fully arranged future plan with a set day uses the present continuous.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'will invite' suggests a decision made now, not a settled arrangement. Misconception: 'will' for an arranged plan.
- **(C)** 'invite' is the simple present for habits. Misconception: present simple for a single arranged event.
- **(D)** 'will be inviting' (future continuous) is heavier than this simple arrangement needs. Misconception: future continuous for a plain plan.

Principle: Present continuous marks a fixed, arranged future plan.

Intuition hook: 'Everything is arranged' calls for 'we are -ing'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Present continuous for an arranged plan

---

Q75. (Explain the error) For a plan already arranged with friends, which is more natural, and why? 'I will meet my friends at the mall tomorrow; we arranged it last week.'

Correct answer: The present continuous is more natural for a plan arranged in advance: 'I am meeting my friends at the mall tomorrow.'

Why: Because the plan was arranged last week, the present continuous fits better than 'will', which usually signals a decision made at the moment of speaking.

Distractor analysis:

• 'will meet' is not wrong grammar, but it hides the fact that the plan was already arranged. Misconception: using 'will' for pre-arranged plans and losing the 'already arranged' meaning.

Principle: For arrangements made in advance, the present continuous is more natural than 'will'.

Intuition hook: Arranged with people, in advance? Prefer 'I am meeting'.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Choosing the best future form

---

Q76. (Multiple choice) I will call you as soon as I ____ home.

Correct answer: (B) reach

Why: After time words like 'as soon as', 'when', and 'after', the future is expressed with the simple present, not 'will'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will reach' puts 'will' inside the time clause, which English avoids. Misconception: doubling 'will' in a time clause.

• **(C)** 'am reaching' is a present arrangement, not the time-clause form. Misconception: continuous inside a time clause.

• **(D)** 'will have reached' over-builds a simple time clause. Misconception: future perfect where the simple present is needed.

Principle: In future time clauses (after when, as soon as, before, after), use the simple present, not 'will'.

Intuition hook: Never use two 'wills': keep the time clause in the plain present.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: No 'will' in future time clauses

---

Q77. (Fill in the blank) If it ____ (rain) tomorrow, we will move the picnic indoors.

Correct answer: rains

Why: In a first-conditional 'if' clause about the future, the verb is in the simple present, not 'will'.

Distractor analysis:

• 'will rain' wrongly puts 'will' inside the if-clause; only the main clause takes 'will'. Misconception: 'will' after 'if'.

Principle: In a future 'if' clause, use the simple present; put 'will' only in the result clause.

Intuition hook: 'If it rains, we will...' – the 'if' half stays plain present.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: No 'will' in the 'if' clause

---

Q78. (Multiple choice) This time tomorrow, we ____ high above the Atlantic Ocean on our flight to New York.

Correct answer: (B) will be flying

Why: 'This time tomorrow' points to a moment when the action will already be in progress, which is the future continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will fly' presents the flight as a whole event, not as in progress at that exact moment. Misconception: simple future where an in-progress future is meant.

• **(C)** 'fly' is the simple present for habits or schedules. Misconception: present tense for a future ongoing action.

• **(D)** 'are flying' suggests an arrangement, but 'this time tomorrow' calls for the in-progress future. Misconception: present continuous instead of future continuous.

Principle: 'This time tomorrow / at 9 tomorrow' with an action in progress uses the future continuous.

Intuition hook: Mid-action at a future moment = will be -ing.
Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Future continuous with a future time point

---

Q79. (Are both acceptable?) Are both acceptable ways to predict the weather? (1) 'I think it will snow tonight.' (2) 'I think it is going to snow tonight.'
Correct answer: (C) Both are acceptable
Why: 'Will' and 'be going to' can both express predictions; with a general opinion like 'I think', either is fine.
Distractor analysis:
- **(A)** 'going to' is also a valid prediction form, so (2) is fine. Misconception: thinking only 'will' can predict.
- **(B)** 'will' is a valid prediction form, so (1) is fine. Misconception: thinking only 'going to' can predict.
- **(D)** Both are grammatical predictions. Misconception: rejecting two correct forms.

Principle: For predictions, 'will' and 'be going to' often overlap and are both acceptable.
Intuition hook: To predict, either 'will' or 'going to' usually works; evidence just tips it toward 'going to'.
Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Recognising acceptable overlap

---

Q80. (Multiple choice) I ____ always be there for you, no matter what happens.
Correct answer: (A) will
Why: A heartfelt promise about the future uses 'will'.
Distractor analysis:
- **(B)** 'am going to' states an intention but sounds flatter than a promise. Misconception: 'going to' for a solemn promise.
- **(C)** 'am' is the simple present and cannot carry this future promise. Misconception: present tense for a future promise.
- **(D)** 'am being' wrongly turns a permanent commitment into temporary behaviour. Misconception: continuous of 'be' for a lasting promise.

Principle: Promises and commitments about the future use 'will'.
Intuition hook: A vow reaches for 'I will'.
Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Will' for a promise

Q81. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'When I will grow up, I will become a pilot.'
Correct answer: When I grow up, I will become a pilot.
Why: The time clause after 'when' takes the simple present; only the main clause keeps 'will'.
Distractor analysis:
- Keeping 'when I will grow up' puts 'will' inside a time clause, which English does not allow. Misconception: 'will' after 'when'.

Principle: Do not use 'will' in a future time clause; use the simple present.
Intuition hook: 'When I grow up' (plain present), then 'I will become' (will).
Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Correcting 'will' in a time clause

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Q82. (Multiple choice) A: 'What are your plans for the summer?' B: 'Well, I ____ a coding course in June — I've already enrolled — and after that I ____ visit my cousins, though I haven't fixed any dates.'
Correct answer: (A) am taking / am going to
Why: The enrolled course is a fixed arrangement (present continuous, 'am taking'); the unfixed cousin visit is an intention (be going to, 'am going to visit').
Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** Both 'will' forms miss the difference between a booked arrangement and a loose intention. Misconception: treating all futures as one.

• **(C)** The simple present cannot express these future plans. Misconception: present tense for future plans.

• **(D)** This swaps the forms: the fixed, enrolled course should be the present continuous, not the visit. Misconception: matching the arrangement form to the wrong plan.

Principle: Fixed arrangement = present continuous; intention with no fixed details = be going to.

Intuition hook: Booked = 'I am -ing'; just intending = 'I'm going to'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Sorting arrangement vs. intention

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Section D — Perfect Tense Reasoning

Q83. (Multiple choice) She ____ three cups of coffee so far today, and it is only 10 a.m.

Correct answer: (B) has drunk

Why: 'So far today' names a period that is not yet finished, so the present perfect is required.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'drank ... so far today' is wrong; an unfinished period cannot take the plain simple past. Misconception: simple past inside an ongoing time period.

• **(C)** 'drinks' is the simple present for habits, not this running total. Misconception: present simple for an up-to-now count.

• **(D)** 'is drinking' means right at this second, not across the morning. Misconception: present continuous for a period up to now.

Principle: An unfinished time period (today, this week, so far) takes the present perfect.

Intuition hook: If the day is not over, the count lives in 'has done'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect for an unfinished period

---

Q84. (Fill in the blank) They ____ (know) each other for more than twenty years.

Correct answer: have known

Why: 'For more than twenty years' up to now, with the stative verb 'know', uses the present perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• 'know ... for twenty years' wrongly uses the simple present for a stretch up to now. Misconception: present simple with a 'for'-duration.

• 'knew' would suggest they no longer know each other. Misconception: simple past for a friendship that continues.

Principle: 'For + duration up to now' uses the present perfect, even with stative verbs.

Intuition hook: 'For twenty years and still counting' = have known.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect with 'for'

Q85. (Multiple choice) Shakespeare ____ many of the most famous plays in the English language.

Correct answer: (B) wrote

Why: Shakespeare's life and writing are completely finished, so his work is described with the simple past.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'has written' wrongly implies the writing is still connected to now or could continue, but he can write no more. Misconception: present perfect for a person whose life is over.

• **(C)** 'had written' needs a second, later past event to sit before. Misconception: past perfect with no second past reference.

• **(D)** 'writes' is the simple present, but he does not write now. Misconception: present tense for a finished body of work.

Principle: The present perfect implies a link to the present; a finished life or period uses the simple past.

Intuition hook: A living artist 'has painted'; a departed one 'painted'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Finished vs. unfinished time

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Q86. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'I have seen that film last night.'

Correct answer: I saw that film last night.

Why: 'Last night' is a definite finished time, which cannot combine with the present perfect, so use the simple past.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'have seen ... last night' pairs the present perfect with a finished time word. Misconception: present perfect with a specific past time.

Principle: The present perfect never takes a definite past-time expression (yesterday, last night, in 2019).

Intuition hook: Name the exact time and you must switch to the simple past.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect vs. simple past with a time word

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Q87. (Multiple choice) ____ you ever ____ to Japan? I mean at any point in your life.

Correct answer: (B) Have / been

Why: A question about life experience up to now uses the present perfect, and 'been' means went and came back.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** The simple past asks about a specific past occasion, not lifelong experience. Misconception: simple past for an 'ever in your life' question.

• **(C)** 'gone' would mean the person is still in Japan now, which does not fit. Misconception: confusing 'been' (returned) with 'gone' (still away).

• **(D)** 'Do you go' asks about a habit, not experience. Misconception: present simple for a life experience.

Principle: Present perfect + 'ever' asks about experience at any time up to now; 'been' = went and returned.

Intuition hook: 'Have you ever been...?' asks about your whole life so far.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect for experience

---

Q88. (Fill in the blank) This is the best pizza I ____ (ever / eat)!

Correct answer: have ever eaten

Why: A superlative ('the best ... ever') looks back over all experience up to now, which is the present perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• 'ever ate' uses the simple past where the 'up to now' experience pattern needs the present perfect. Misconception: simple past in a 'best ... ever' structure.

Principle: Superlative + 'ever' (the best I have ever...) uses the present perfect.

Intuition hook: 'Best ... I've ever had' is a fixed present-perfect pattern.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect with a superlative

---

Q89. (Multiple choice) You've missed her by a minute. She ____ left the building.

Correct answer: (B) has just

Why: A very recent action with a present result uses the present perfect with 'just': has + just + past participle.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'she just left' drops the auxiliary needed here for the present-result meaning. Misconception: leaving out 'has'.

• **(C)** 'just has left' mis-orders the adverb. Misconception: wrong placement of 'just'.

• **(D)** 'had just left' is past perfect and needs a second past event. Misconception: past perfect with no second past point.

Principle: Present perfect with 'just' = a moment-ago action that still matters now.

Intuition hook: 'She has just left' = gone seconds ago, so you missed her.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect with 'just'

Q90. (Explain the error) Explain when you would use each sentence: (1) 'I have lost my umbrella.' (2) 'I lost my umbrella.'

Correct answer: (1) The present perfect stresses the present result: it is still lost, I do not have it now. (2) The simple past just reports a past event, perhaps one that is now over (I may have found it since).

Why: The present perfect connects the past action to the present situation; the simple past simply places the event in the past with no stated link to now.

Distractor analysis:

• Treating the two as identical misses that the present perfect signals a result that still holds. Misconception: assuming 'have lost' and 'lost' always mean the same.

Principle: Present perfect = past action with present relevance; simple past = past event, no stated present link.

Intuition hook: 'I have lost it' = still gone now; 'I lost it' = just a past fact.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Present relevance vs. plain past

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Q91. (Multiple choice) By the time the teacher collected the answer sheets, most students ____ only half of the questions.

Correct answer: (B) had answered

Why: 'By the time (past)' with an action completed before that past point uses the past perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'answered' lacks the 'had' that 'by the time' requires to mark the earlier completion. Misconception: simple past after 'by the time'.

• **(C)** 'have answered' is present perfect and clashes with the past setting. Misconception: present perfect in a past story.

• **(D)** 'were answering' is ongoing, not completed by that point. Misconception: continuous for a by-then result.

Principle: 'By the time (past), ... had (done)' uses the past perfect for the earlier completed action.

Intuition hook: 'By the time' looks back, so reach for 'had'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect after 'by the time'

Q92. (Fill in the blank) Please don't arrive at 6. By then I ____ (not / finish) cooking, and the food won't be ready.

Correct answer: will not have finished (won't have finished)

Why: 'By then (a future point)' with an action not yet complete uses the future perfect, here in the negative.

Distractor analysis:

• 'will not finish' does not express 'not yet done by that future point'. Misconception: simple future where the future perfect is needed.

Principle: Future perfect (will have + past participle) marks completion, or non-completion, by a future time.

Intuition hook: 'By 6 it still won't be done' = won't have finished.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Negative future perfect

Q93. (Multiple choice) We have been standing here ____ 45 minutes, ____ the doors first opened.

Correct answer: (B) for / since

Why: 'For' introduces a length of time (45 minutes); 'since' introduces a starting point (when the doors opened).

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** This reverses them: '45 minutes' is a length (for), and 'the doors opened' is a starting point (since). Misconception: swapping 'for' and 'since'.
- **(C)** 'for the doors opened' is wrong; a starting point needs 'since'. Misconception: 'for' before an event.
- **(D)** 'since 45 minutes' is wrong; a length of time needs 'for'. Misconception: 'since' before a duration.

Principle: 'For' + a length of time; 'since' + a point in time or an event.

Intuition hook: 'For' measures how long; 'since' marks when it started.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: 'For' vs. 'since'

Q94. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'We are living in this house since 2018.'

Correct answer: We have been living (or have lived) in this house since 2018.

Why: A situation continuing from a past starting point up to now uses the present perfect (or present perfect continuous), not the present continuous.

Distractor analysis:

- Keeping 'are living ... since 2018' pairs the present continuous with 'since', which does not work. Misconception: present continuous for a stretch up to now.

Principle: 'Since + a past point, continuing to now' uses the present perfect, not the present continuous.

Intuition hook: 'Since 2018 up to today' = have been living, never 'are living'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Correcting a 'since' + continuous error

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Q95. (Multiple choice) A: 'Have you sent the report?' B: 'Yes, I've ____ sent it — earlier than the deadline.'

Correct answer: (B) already

Why: 'Already' marks a completed action, often sooner than expected, in a positive statement.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'yet' belongs in questions and negatives, not this positive answer. Misconception: using 'yet' in an affirmative sentence.
- **(C)** 'still' suggests continuation, not completion. Misconception: 'still' for a finished action.
- **(D)** 'ever' asks about experience, not completion. Misconception: 'ever' in a completed-action statement.

Principle: 'Already' = completed, often earlier than expected (positive); 'yet' = questions and negatives.

Intuition hook: Done (maybe early)? 'already'. Not done / asking? 'yet'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Already' vs. 'yet'

Q96. (Fill in the blank) I'm sorry, I haven't finished reading your essay ____.

Correct answer: yet

Why: 'Yet' is used with the present perfect in negatives and questions to mean 'up to now, not done'.

Distractor analysis:

- 'already' would wrongly claim completion in a negative sentence. Misconception: 'already' in a negative.

Principle: 'Yet' is for negatives and questions; 'already' is for positives.

Intuition hook: Not done so far = 'not ... yet'.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Yet' in a negative

Q97. (Multiple choice) 'Why are you so out of breath right now?' 'Because I ____ to catch the bus.'

Correct answer: (B) have been running

Why: A recent, ongoing activity that explains a present state (breathlessness) uses the present perfect continuous.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'have run' stresses completion, not the ongoing activity behind the breathlessness. Misconception: perfect simple where the ongoing cause is meant.
- **(C)** 'run' is the simple present for habits. Misconception: present simple for a recent activity.
- **(D)** 'ran' cuts the action off from the present, but the effect is felt now. Misconception: simple past detaching from the present state.

Principle: Present perfect continuous explains a present state through a recent, ongoing activity.

Intuition hook: Out of breath now because you have been -ing.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect continuous for a present result

---

Q98. (Multiple choice) Look how much she has done! She ____ ten thank-you cards already.

Correct answer: (A) has written

Why: When we count a finished number of results (ten cards), we use the present perfect simple, not the continuous.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'has been writing ten cards' is wrong; the continuous stresses ongoing activity, not a completed count. Misconception: perfect continuous with a finished number.
- **(C)** 'wrote ... already' clashes; 'already' pairs with the present perfect here. Misconception: simple past with 'already' in this present-result context.
- **(D)** 'writes' is the simple present for habits. Misconception: present simple for a completed count.

Principle: Present perfect simple counts completed results; present perfect continuous stresses ongoing activity and duration.

Intuition hook: Counting finished things? Perfect simple. Stressing how long? Perfect continuous.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Perfect simple (result) vs. continuous (activity)

Q99. (Explain the error) Explain why this is wrong and correct it: 'I have been reading this book three times.'

Correct answer: A number of completed times uses the present perfect simple: 'I have read this book three times.'

Why: The present perfect continuous describes ongoing or repeated activity in terms of duration, not a countable number of finished repetitions; for 'three times', use the present perfect simple.

Distractor analysis:

- Keeping the continuous with 'three times' mixes duration-focus with a finished count. Misconception: using the perfect continuous to count completed repetitions.

Principle: Count completed occurrences with the present perfect simple, not the continuous.

Intuition hook: 'Three times' counts finished events, so use 'have read', not 'have been reading'.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Perfect simple with a count

---

Q100. (Multiple choice) Call me any time after 9 tonight; I ____ dinner by then.

Correct answer: (B) will have finished

Why: 'By then (a future point)' with the action already complete uses the future perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will finish' does not stress that it is already done by that time. Misconception: simple future for a by-then completion.

• **(C)** 'finish' is the simple present. Misconception: present tense for a future completion.

• **(D)** 'am finishing' is a present arrangement, not a future completion. Misconception: present continuous for the future perfect.

Principle: Future perfect = completed before a stated future point.

Intuition hook: 'Done by then' = will have done.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Future perfect for completion

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Q101. (Fill in the blank) By the time you read this note, I ____ (already / leave) for the airport.

Correct answer: will have already left

Why: 'By the time you read this (a future point)' with an action completed before it uses the future perfect, and 'already' fits the completed sense.

Distractor analysis:

• 'will already leave' or 'have already left' miss the future-perfect form needed for completion before a future point. Misconception: simple future or present perfect for a future-perfect meaning.

Principle: Future perfect marks an action completed before a future moment.

Intuition hook: 'By the time you do X, I will have done Y' = future perfect.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Future perfect with 'by the time'

Q102. (Multiple choice) It's wonderful to see you again! A lot ____ since we last met.

Correct answer: (B) has happened

Why: 'Since (a past point) up to now' uses the present perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'happened ... since' is wrong; 'since' does not pair with the plain simple past. Misconception: simple past with 'since'.

• **(C)** 'had happened' needs a past setting to sit before. Misconception: past perfect with no past reference point.

• **(D)** 'happens' is the simple present for habits. Misconception: present simple for a period up to now.

Principle: 'Since + a past point, continuing to now' uses the present perfect.

Intuition hook: 'Since we met' looks up to today, so use 'has happened'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect with 'since'

Q103. (Are both acceptable?) Are both acceptable? (1) 'I have finished my work, so I can go home now.' (2) 'I finished my work, so I can go home now.'

Correct answer: (C) Both are acceptable; (1) stresses the present result

Why: Both are grammatical; the present perfect in (1) highlights the present result (the work is done, so I can leave now), while the simple past in (2) simply states the completed action.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** Sentence (2) is also grammatical. Misconception: thinking only the present perfect can link to now.

• **(B)** Sentence (1) is also grammatical. Misconception: rejecting a correct present perfect.

• **(D)** Both are correct English. Misconception: over-rejecting acceptable forms.

Principle: Both present perfect and simple past can report a completed action; the present perfect adds emphasis on the present result.

Intuition hook: Both work; 'have finished' just spotlights that it is done right now.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Recognising acceptable overlap with nuance

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Q104. (Multiple choice) By the time Ravi turns eighteen next month, he ____ in six different cities, because his family ____ so often over the years.

Correct answer: (A) will have lived / has moved

Why: The first blank looks at a total completed by a future point (future perfect); the second looks at repeated action up to now (present perfect).

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** Both simple pasts ignore the future deadline and the up-to-now repetition. Misconception: flattening two different time frames into the simple past.
- **(C)** Simple future and present miss both the completion-by-a-future-point and the up-to-now sense. Misconception: ignoring the perfect aspect entirely.
- **(D)** 'has lived' misses the future deadline, and 'had moved' needs a past frame. Misconception: mismatching each clause's time frame.

Principle: Match each clause to its own time frame: completion by a future point = future perfect; repetition up to now = present perfect.

Intuition hook: Read each half separately: future deadline vs. up-to-now history.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Coordinating two perfect tenses

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Section E — Time Markers vs. Real Meaning

Q105. (Multiple choice) It is now 4 p.m. I ____ several emails this morning, but this afternoon I have been stuck in meetings.

Correct answer: (B) wrote

Why: By 4 p.m. the morning is over, so 'this morning' is now a finished period and takes the simple past; the afternoon is still going, which is why it uses the present perfect.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'have written this morning' would only work while the morning is still in progress, but it is now afternoon. Misconception: assuming 'this morning' always triggers the present perfect.
- **(C)** 'write' is the simple present for habits. Misconception: present simple for a completed morning.
- **(D)** 'had written' needs a second past event to precede. Misconception: past perfect with no reference point.

Principle: The same day-phrase can be finished or unfinished; a completed period takes the simple past, an ongoing one the present perfect.

Intuition hook: If the morning is over, 'this morning' becomes plain past.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Finished vs. unfinished period

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Q106. (Multiple choice) Please don't be upset with me — I ____ want to help you, nothing more.

Correct answer: (B) just want

Why: Here 'just' means 'only / simply', not 'a moment ago', so it does not signal the present perfect; 'want' is stative and takes the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'have just wanted' misreads 'just' as 'recently', but here it means 'only'. Misconception: treating every 'just' as a present-perfect signal.
- **(C)** 'just wanted' shifts a present feeling into the past. Misconception: past tense for a present desire.
- **(D)** 'am just wanting' forces the stative verb 'want' into the continuous. Misconception: continuous with a desire verb.

Principle: 'Just' can mean 'only / simply', which carries no tense signal at all; read its meaning first.

Intuition hook: 'I just want to help' = 'I only want to help'; no present perfect needed.
Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Reading 'just' as 'only'

Q107. (Multiple choice) Since you ____ Spanish so fluently, could you translate this letter for me?
Correct answer: (B) speak
Why: Here 'since' means 'because', not a point in time, so it gives no tense signal; a general ability uses the simple present.
Distractor analysis:
- **(A)** 'have spoken' misreads 'since' as a time marker for the present perfect. Misconception: assuming 'since' always triggers the present perfect.
- **(C)** 'spoke' places the ability in the past, but it is a present skill. Misconception: past tense for a current ability.
- **(D)** 'are speaking' suggests a temporary action now, not a permanent ability. Misconception: continuous for a stable skill.

Principle: 'Since' can mean 'because'; then it carries no tense signal and the meaning decides the tense.
Intuition hook: 'Since = because' means ignore the time reflex and read the sense.
Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Reading 'since' as 'because'

Q108. (Multiple choice) These days, I ____ to school because the roads near my house are being repaired.
Correct answer: (B) am walking
Why: 'These days ... because the roads are being repaired' describes a temporary situation, so use the present continuous, not the simple present.
Distractor analysis:
- **(A)** 'walk' would mean a permanent habit, but this is a temporary change. Misconception: assuming 'these days' means the simple present.
- **(C)** 'walked' is past, but the situation is present. Misconception: past tense for a current situation.
- **(D)** 'have walked' stresses a completed or up-to-now action, not the temporary routine. Misconception: present perfect for a passing phase.

Principle: 'These days' often marks a temporary current situation, which takes the present continuous.
Intuition hook: 'These days' can mean 'for now', so reach for '-ing'.
Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: 'These days' as temporary

---

Q109. (Are both acceptable?) Are both acceptable? (1) 'I have recently read a wonderful book.' (2) 'I recently read a wonderful book.'
Correct answer: (C) Both are acceptable
Why: 'Recently' pairs naturally with both the present perfect and the simple past, so both sentences are correct.
Distractor analysis:
- **(A)** The simple past with 'recently' is also fine. Misconception: thinking 'recently' forces the present perfect.
- **(B)** The present perfect with 'recently' is also fine. Misconception: rejecting a correct present perfect.
- **(D)** Both are grammatical. Misconception: over-rejecting acceptable forms.

Principle: Some markers (recently, already) work with more than one tense; the marker does not force a single answer.
Intuition hook: 'Recently' happily follows either 'I have read' or 'I read'.
Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: A marker that allows two tenses

---

Q110. (Multiple choice) I'll send you a message the moment the film ____.

Correct answer: (B) ends

Why: After 'the moment / when / as soon as', a future idea is expressed with the simple present, not 'will'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'will end' wrongly puts 'will' inside a future time clause. Misconception: 'when' always means the past, or 'will' belongs in the time clause.
- **(C)** 'ended' is past, but the whole sentence points to the future. Misconception: 'the moment / when' forces the past.
- **(D)** 'is ending' is a present action, not the time-clause form. Misconception: continuous in a future time clause.

Principle: In a future time clause, use the simple present; 'when / the moment' do not force the past.

Intuition hook: 'The moment it ends, I'll text' – plain present in the time half.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: 'When' is not always past

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Q111. (Multiple choice) My grandmother ____ a kind word for everyone she meets; she always has, and everyone loves her for it.

Correct answer: (A) has

Why: 'Always' here describes a permanent, ongoing trait, which uses the simple present; 'have' (possess) is stative, so no continuous.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'is having' would suggest temporary or deliberate behaviour and forces the stative 'have' into the continuous. Misconception: 'always + continuous' for a permanent trait.
- **(C)** 'had' is past, but the trait is present and lasting. Misconception: past tense for a continuing characteristic.
- **(D)** 'will have' points to the future, but this is her present, established nature. Misconception: future for a present trait.

Principle: 'Always' with a permanent trait uses the simple present; the continuous 'is always -ing' is for temporary or annoying repetition.

Intuition hook: A lasting good quality is plain present; only the complaining 'always' takes '-ing'.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Two meanings of 'always'

Q112. (Fill in the blank) It is late at night now, and I am exhausted. I ____ (do) so much today that I can barely keep my eyes open.

Correct answer: have done

Why: Even at night, 'today' is still the current, unfinished day being felt right now, so the present perfect links the day's efforts to the present exhaustion.

Distractor analysis:

- 'did so much today' loses the link to the present tiredness; the day is still 'now', so the present perfect fits the ongoing period and result. Misconception: simple past for an unfinished day with a present result.

Principle: 'Today' as an unfinished period, with a present result, uses the present perfect.

Intuition hook: The day isn't over and you feel it now, so 'I have done'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect for the current day

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Q113. (Multiple choice) I ____ her three years ago, and we ____ good friends ever since.

Correct answer: (B) met / have been

Why: 'Ago' names a finished past time and forces the simple past ('met'); 'ever since' points from that time up to now and forces the present perfect ('have been').

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'have met ... ago' is impossible; the present perfect never takes 'ago'. Misconception: present perfect with 'ago'.
- **(C)** 'are ... ever since' is wrong; 'ever since' requires the present perfect. Misconception: present simple with 'ever since'.
- **(D)** This gets both wrong at once. Misconception: mismatching both markers.

Principle: 'Ago' forces the simple past; 'ever since' forces the present perfect, even in one sentence.

Intuition hook: 'Ago' = plain past; 'ever since' = have/has been.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Two markers, two tenses

Q114. (Multiple choice) 'Has the post arrived?' 'Yes, the postman ____ it just now.'

Correct answer: (B) delivered

Why: As a phrase meaning 'a moment ago', 'just now' takes the simple past, unlike 'just' alone, which takes the present perfect.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'has delivered' is tempting, but the phrase 'just now' (a moment ago) pairs with the simple past. Misconception: treating 'just now' like the present-perfect 'just'.
- **(C)** 'delivers' is the simple present for habits. Misconception: present simple for a moment-ago action.
- **(D)** 'had delivered' needs a second past event. Misconception: past perfect with no reference point.

Principle: 'Just now' (= a moment ago) takes the simple past; 'just' alone (has just done) takes the present perfect.

Intuition hook: 'He left just now' (past) vs. 'he has just left' (present perfect).

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Just now' vs. 'just'

Q115. (Multiple choice) You look worn out. ____ you ____ enough sleep lately?

Correct answer: (B) Have / been getting

Why: 'Lately' refers to a period reaching up to now, so it takes the present perfect (here the continuous form for an ongoing pattern).

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** The simple past asks about one finished occasion, not a recent stretch up to now. Misconception: simple past with 'lately'.
- **(C)** 'Do you get' asks about a permanent habit, not the recent period. Misconception: present simple for 'lately'.
- **(D)** The past perfect needs a past reference point. Misconception: past perfect with no anchor.

Principle: 'Lately / recently' about a period up to now uses the present perfect.

Intuition hook: 'Lately' looks back toward today, so use 'have you been -ing'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Lately' triggers the present perfect

---

Q116. (Explain the error) A student always chooses the simple past whenever she sees 'yesterday'. Explain why this sentence still needs the past perfect: 'By yesterday evening, the workers had already repaired the broken road.'

Correct answer: 'Yesterday evening' sets a past reference point; the repair was completed before that point, so the past perfect ('had repaired') is correct.

Why: The marker 'yesterday' only tells you the story is in the past; it does not decide between simple past and past perfect. The meaning, one event finished before another past point, calls for the past perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• Reading 'yesterday' as an automatic simple-past trigger ignores that the action finished before a past point. Misconception: markers choose the tense; in fact meaning chooses the aspect.

Principle: A time marker sets the general time; the relationship between events chooses simple past vs. past perfect.

Intuition hook: 'Yesterday' says 'this is past'; the earlier-than-past meaning says 'use had'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Marker sets time, meaning sets aspect

---

Q117. (Multiple choice) When I was a child, we ____ to the seaside every single summer.

Correct answer: (B) went

Why: 'Every summer' marks a habit, but 'when I was a child' fixes that habit firmly in the past, so use the simple past for a past habit.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'go' is the present-tense habit form, but the habit belongs to the past. Misconception: 'every summer' forces the simple present even inside a past frame.

• **(C)** 'have gone' would link the trips to now, but they are finished childhood trips. Misconception: present perfect for a finished past habit.

• **(D)** 'had gone' needs a second past event to precede. Misconception: past perfect with no reference point.

Principle: A habit set in the past ('when I was young ... every day') uses the simple past.

Intuition hook: 'Every summer' inside 'when I was a child' becomes a past habit: 'we went'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Habit marker inside a past frame

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Q118. (Fill in the blank) So far this season, our school team ____ (win) every single match they have played.

Correct answer: has won

Why: 'So far this season' is an ongoing, unfinished period, so it takes the present perfect.

Distractor analysis:

• 'won' treats the season as finished, but 'so far' shows it is still going. Misconception: simple past for an unfinished stretch.

Principle: 'So far' marks an unfinished period and uses the present perfect.

Intuition hook: 'So far' = up to now, so 'has won'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: 'So far' triggers the present perfect

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Q119. (Multiple choice) The moment the teacher ____ the results, I will run to tell you.

Correct answer: (B) announces

Why: 'The moment' introduces a future time clause, which takes the simple present, not 'will'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will announce' wrongly puts 'will' in a time clause. Misconception: 'will' inside a future time clause.

• **(C)** 'announced' is past, but the sentence looks to the future. Misconception: past tense for a future time clause.

• **(D)** 'is announcing' is a present action, not the time-clause form. Misconception: continuous in a time clause.

Principle: Future time clauses (the moment, when, as soon as) use the simple present.

Intuition hook: Keep 'will' out of the 'the moment ...' clause.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple present in a future time clause

---

Q120. (Multiple choice) Choose the set that fits: 'As soon as the bell ____, we ____ home, and by the time we get there, dinner ____ ready and waiting.'

Correct answer: (A) rings / will go / will be

Why: The time clause after 'as soon as' takes the simple present ('rings'); the main action is future ('will go'); and the future state of dinner uses the simple future ('will be').

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'will ring' wrongly puts 'will' in the time clause, and 'go' drops the future in the main clause. Misconception: reversing where 'will' belongs.
- **(C)** 'go' and 'is' both miss the future meaning of the main clauses. Misconception: present tense for future actions and states.
- **(D)** 'is' fails to mark dinner's readiness as a future state. Misconception: present tense for a future situation.

Principle: Simple present in the time clause; 'will' in the main clauses that describe the future.

Intuition hook: Time clause stays present; the rest of the future gets 'will'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Coordinating time-clause present with future main clauses

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Section F — Irregular Verbs Inside Tense Contexts

Q121. (Multiple choice) The film had already ____ by the time we found our seats.

Correct answer: (B) begun

Why: After 'had', the past perfect needs the past participle 'begun', not the simple past 'began'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'began' is the simple past form and cannot follow 'had'. Misconception: using the past-tense form where the participle is required.
- **(C)** 'begin' is the base form. Misconception: base form after an auxiliary.
- **(D)** 'beginning' is the -ing form, wrong here. Misconception: -ing after 'had'.

Principle: Past perfect = had + past participle (begin → began → begun).

Intuition hook: After 'had', use the third form: begun, not began.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Participle in the past perfect

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Q122. (Fill in the blank) I have never ____ (see) such a beautiful sunset in my whole life.

Correct answer: seen

Why: The present perfect uses the past participle 'seen', not the simple past 'saw'.

Distractor analysis:

- 'saw' is the simple past and cannot follow 'have'. Misconception: past-tense form inside the present perfect.

Principle: Present perfect = have/has + past participle (see → saw → seen).

Intuition hook: 'Have seen', never 'have saw'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Participle in the present perfect

---

Q123. (Multiple choice) ____ you ____ your subjects for next year yet?

Correct answer: (B) Have / chosen

Why: 'Yet' calls for the present perfect, which uses the participle 'chosen'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'chose' is the simple past, wrong after 'have', and 'Did ... yet' is less natural here. Misconception: past-tense form after 'have'.
- **(C)** 'choose' is the base form, wrong after 'have'. Misconception: base form in the present perfect.
- **(D)** 'Did ... chosen' mixes 'did' with a participle. Misconception: 'did' plus participle.

Principle: Present perfect with 'yet' uses have/has + past participle (choose → chose → chosen).
Intuition hook: 'Have you chosen ... yet?' – never 'have you chose'.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Participle with 'yet'

Q124. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'Someone has broke the classroom window.'
Correct answer: Someone has broken the classroom window.
Why: The present perfect needs the participle 'broken', not the simple past 'broke'.
Distractor analysis:
• Keeping 'has broke' uses the past-tense form after 'has'. Misconception: past form (broke) where the participle (broken) is needed.
Principle: Present perfect = has/have + past participle (break → broke → broken).
Intuition hook: 'Has broken', never 'has broke'.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Correcting a participle error

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Q125. (Multiple choice) By the time she reached the shop, she ____ what she had planned to buy.
Correct answer: (B) had forgotten
Why: 'By the time (past)' calls for the past perfect, using the participle 'forgotten' for the earlier event.
Distractor analysis:
• **(A)** 'forgot' lacks the 'had' that 'by the time' needs, and would be the wrong aspect. Misconception: simple past after 'by the time'.
• **(C)** 'has forgotten' is present perfect and clashes with the past setting. Misconception: present perfect in a past story.
• **(D)** 'forgets' is the simple present. Misconception: present tense for a past event.
Principle: Past perfect = had + past participle (forget → forgot → forgotten).
Intuition hook: Forgotten before she arrived: 'had forgotten'.
Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Participle in the past perfect after 'by the time'

Q126. (Fill in the blank) The school choir ____ (sing) three lovely songs at yesterday's concert.
Correct answer: sang
Why: 'Yesterday' calls for the simple past 'sang'; without an auxiliary, the participle 'sung' would be wrong.
Distractor analysis:
• 'sung' is the past participle and cannot stand alone as a simple past; it needs 'have' or 'had'. Misconception: using the participle (sung) as a simple past.
Principle: Simple past uses the past-tense form (sing → sang); the participle (sung) needs an auxiliary.
Intuition hook: Alone in the past, it is 'sang'; with 'have/had', it is 'sung'.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past form vs. participle

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Q127. (Multiple choice) She ____ my pen about an hour ago and still hasn't given it back.
Correct answer: (B) took
Why: 'An hour ago' is a finished past time and forces the simple past 'took'.
Distractor analysis:
• **(A)** 'has taken ... ago' is impossible; the present perfect never takes 'ago'. Misconception: present perfect with 'ago'.
• **(C)** 'had taken' needs a second past event to precede. Misconception: past perfect with no reference point.
• **(D)** 'taken' is a participle and cannot stand alone. Misconception: bare participle as a simple past.
Principle: 'Ago' forces the simple past (take → took).

Intuition hook: 'An hour ago' = plain past: 'she took it'.
Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past with 'ago'

Q128. (Fill in the blank) Have you ever ____ (speak) to someone famous in real life?
Correct answer: spoken
Why: The present perfect with 'ever' uses the participle 'spoken'.
Distractor analysis:
- 'spoke' is the simple past and cannot follow 'have'. Misconception: past-tense form in the present perfect.

Principle: Present perfect = have + past participle (speak → spoke → spoken).
Intuition hook: 'Have you ever spoken', never 'have you spoke'.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Participle with 'ever'

Q129. (Multiple choice) By next Friday, I ____ all five of my essays and can finally relax.
Correct answer: (B) will have written
Why: 'By next Friday (a future point)' with completion uses the future perfect, which takes the participle 'written'.
Distractor analysis:
- **(A)** 'will write' does not stress that all five are finished by that point. Misconception: simple future for a by-then completion.
- **(C)** 'wrote' is past, but the deadline is in the future. Misconception: past tense for a future completion.
- **(D)** 'have written' is present perfect, not tied to the future deadline. Misconception: present perfect for a future point.

Principle: Future perfect = will have + past participle (write → wrote → written).
Intuition hook: Done by a future date = 'will have written'.
Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Participle in the future perfect

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Q130. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'I have went to the dentist twice this month.'
Correct answer: I have gone to the dentist twice this month.
Why: The present perfect needs the participle 'gone', not the simple past 'went'.
Distractor analysis:
- Keeping 'have went' uses the past-tense form after 'have'. Misconception: past form (went) where the participle (gone) is required.

Principle: Present perfect = have + past participle (go → went → gone).
Intuition hook: 'Have gone', never 'have went'.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Correcting a participle error

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Q131. (Multiple choice) Yesterday, my cousin ____ me a lovely gift from her trip abroad.
Correct answer: (B) brought
Why: 'Yesterday' forces the simple past 'brought' (which happens to look the same as the participle, but here the tense must be simple past).
Distractor analysis:
- **(A)** 'has brought ... yesterday' pairs the present perfect with a finished time. Misconception: present perfect with 'yesterday'.
- **(C)** 'had brought' needs a second past event. Misconception: past perfect with no reference point.
- **(D)** 'brings' is the simple present. Misconception: present tense for a past event.

Principle: 'Yesterday' forces the simple past, even when the past and participle forms look identical (brought).

Intuition hook: Same-looking forms still need the right tense: 'yesterday' means simple past.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Tense choice when forms coincide

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Q132. (Multiple choice) Mr. Khan ____ at our school since 2015 and still teaches us today.
Correct answer: (B) has taught
Why: 'Since 2015' up to now, with the action continuing, uses the present perfect and the participle 'taught'.
Distractor analysis:
• **(A)** 'taught' (simple past) would suggest he no longer teaches there. Misconception: simple past for an ongoing situation.
• **(C)** 'had taught' needs a past reference point. Misconception: past perfect with no anchor.
• **(D)** 'teaches ... since 2015' is wrong; 'since' does not pair with the simple present. Misconception: present simple with 'since'.
Principle: 'Since + a past point, still true now' uses the present perfect (teach → taught → taught).
Intuition hook: 'Since 2015 and still here' = 'has taught'.
Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect with 'since'

Q133. (Fill in the blank) The concert ____ (begin) at 7 p.m. sharp yesterday, but by 7:30 the singer ____ (already / begin) her third song.
Correct answer: began; had already begun
Why: The first verb is a plain past event ('began'); the second happened before the past point 7:30, so it takes the past perfect participle ('had begun').
Distractor analysis:
• Using 'began' in both blanks misses that the third song had started before 7:30. Misconception: not marking the earlier event with the past perfect.
• Using 'begun' alone in the first blank drops the needed 'had'. Misconception: participle without an auxiliary in a simple-past slot.
Principle: One irregular verb takes different forms by aspect: simple past 'began' vs. past perfect 'had begun'.
Intuition hook: Same verb, two jobs: 'began' for the plain event, 'had begun' for the earlier one.
Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Same verb across two aspects

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Q134. (Multiple choice) Last week, our club ____ a brand-new captain for the season.
Correct answer: (B) chose
Why: 'Last week' is a finished past time and forces the simple past 'chose'.
Distractor analysis:
• **(A)** 'has chosen ... last week' pairs the present perfect with a finished time. Misconception: present perfect with a dated past time.
• **(C)** 'had chosen' needs a second past event. Misconception: past perfect with no reference point.
• **(D)** 'chosen' is a participle and cannot stand alone. Misconception: bare participle as a simple past.
Principle: A finished past time forces the simple past (choose → chose); the participle (chosen) needs an auxiliary.
Intuition hook: 'Last week' means simple past: 'chose', not 'chosen'.
Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past form vs. participle

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Q135. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'I seen him at the mall yesterday.'
Correct answer: I saw him at the mall yesterday.

Why: 'Seen' is the past participle and cannot stand alone as a simple past; with 'yesterday', use the simple past 'saw'.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'I seen' uses a participle with no auxiliary. Misconception: using 'seen' as a stand-alone simple past instead of 'saw'.

Principle: Use the simple past 'saw' alone; 'seen' only appears with 'have' or 'had'.

Intuition hook: 'I saw it' (alone) vs. 'I have seen it' (with have).

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past vs. participle form

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Q136. (Multiple choice) Choose the correct set: 'I ____ that movie three times already: I first ____ it back in 2022, and I ____ it again just last week.'

Correct answer: (A) have seen / saw / saw

Why: 'Three times already' up to now uses the present perfect ('have seen'); the two specific past occasions ('in 2022', 'last week') use the simple past ('saw').

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** This uses the simple past for the up-to-now total and the present perfect with dated times, both backwards. Misconception: swapping the two tenses.

• **(C)** 'have seen ... in 2022' pairs the present perfect with a dated time. Misconception: present perfect with a specific past date.

• **(D)** 'saw ... three times already' ignores the up-to-now meaning of 'already'. Misconception: simple past for a running total.

Principle: Up-to-now total = present perfect ('have seen'); specific past occasions = simple past ('saw').

Intuition hook: 'Three times up to now' is 'have seen'; a named past day is 'saw'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Coordinating irregular forms across tenses

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Section G — Stative Verbs and the Continuous Trap

Q137. (Multiple choice) This old wooden box ____ all of my grandmother's letters.

Correct answer: (B) contains

Why: 'Contain' is a stative verb, so it uses the simple present and rejects the continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'is containing' forces a stative verb into the continuous. Misconception: -ing with a 'containing' verb.

• **(C)** 'is contained' is passive and changes the meaning. Misconception: passive where an active state is meant.

• **(D)** 'contain' does not agree with the singular subject 'box'. Misconception: subject-verb mismatch.

Principle: Stative verbs like contain, consist, and include take the simple present.

Intuition hook: A box just 'contains'; it is never 'in the middle of containing'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb 'contain'

Q138. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'I am believing that honesty is always the best policy.'

Correct answer: I believe that honesty is always the best policy.

Why: 'Believe' is a stative verb of opinion, so it takes the simple present, not the continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'am believing' forces a belief into the continuous. Misconception: -ing with a belief verb.

Principle: Verbs of opinion (believe, think = opinion, doubt) are stative.

Intuition hook: A belief is a settled state, so 'I believe', never 'I am believing'.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb 'believe'

Q139. (Multiple choice) In which sentence is the -ing form of 'have' CORRECT?

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'Have a wonderful time' means 'experience', a dynamic action, so the continuous is correct; the other sentences use 'have' for possession or characteristics, which is stative.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'have a laptop' is possession; it should be 'I have a new laptop'. Misconception: continuous with 'have' as possession.
- **(C)** 'have brown eyes' is a characteristic; it should be 'she has brown eyes'. Misconception: continuous with a physical trait.
- **(D)** 'have three children' is possession; it should be 'they have three children'. Misconception: continuous with 'have' as possession.

Principle: 'Have' is stative for possession/traits but dynamic in expressions like 'have a good time / have lunch / have a shower'.

Intuition hook: Own something = 'I have'; do or experience something = 'I am having'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Dynamic vs. stative 'have'

Q140. (Fill in the blank) Mmm, this fresh bread ____ (smell) absolutely wonderful.

Correct answer: smells

Why: Here 'smell' describes the bread's quality (a perception state), so it uses the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

- 'is smelling' would mean actively sniffing, not the bread's quality. Misconception: continuous for a perception state.

Principle: Perception verbs (smell, taste, look) describing a quality are stative and take the simple present.

Intuition hook: The bread 'smells' good; you 'are smelling' it only if you deliberately sniff.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative perception verb

Q141. (Multiple choice) The chef ____ the sauce right now to check it, and she says it ____ just perfect.

Correct answer: (B) is tasting / tastes

Why: 'Is tasting' is the deliberate action of sampling (dynamic); 'tastes' describes the sauce's quality (stative).

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** This reverses them: the sampling is the action, and the quality is the state. Misconception: swapping the dynamic and stative uses.
- **(C)** The quality of the sauce is a state, not an ongoing action. Misconception: continuous for a quality.
- **(D)** The chef's deliberate sampling right now is an action, not a state. Misconception: simple present for a deliberate action in progress.

Principle: 'Taste' as a deliberate action is dynamic (is tasting); 'taste' as a quality is stative (tastes).

Intuition hook: You 'are tasting' the soup (action); the soup 'tastes' good (quality).

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Dynamic vs. stative perception

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Q142. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'This suitcase is weighing exactly twenty kilograms.'

Correct answer: This suitcase weighs exactly twenty kilograms.

Why: Here 'weigh' states a measurement (a stative fact), so it takes the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'is weighing' treats a fixed measurement as an ongoing action. Misconception: continuous for a measurement. (Only 'weighing the suitcase' as the act of putting it on a scale would be dynamic.)

Principle: 'Weigh / cost / measure' as a fixed value are stative; only the act of measuring is dynamic.

Intuition hook: The bag 'weighs' 20 kg (fact); you 'are weighing' it only while on the scale.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Measurement verbs as stative

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Q143. (Multiple choice) This maths problem ____ difficult at first, but it is actually easy once you spot the trick.

Correct answer: (B) seems

Why: 'Seem' is a stative verb of appearance and takes the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'is seeming' forces a stative verb into the continuous. Misconception: -ing with 'seem'.

• **(C)** 'seem' does not agree with the singular subject. Misconception: subject-verb mismatch.

• **(D)** 'is seemed' is not a valid form. Misconception: inventing a passive of 'seem'.

Principle: 'Seem' and 'appear' (= look like) are stative.

Intuition hook: Something 'seems' hard; it is never 'seeming'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb 'seem'

Q144. (Fill in the blank) I'm so sorry — I ____ (not / remember) your name at all.

Correct answer: do not remember (don't remember)

Why: 'Remember' is a stative verb of memory, so it takes the simple present, here in the negative.

Distractor analysis:

• 'am not remembering' forces a stative verb into the continuous. Misconception: -ing with a memory verb.

Principle: Verbs of memory (remember, forget, recall) are usually stative.

Intuition hook: You 'remember' or you don't; you are never 'remembering' in this sense.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb 'remember'

Q145. (Multiple choice) Whose umbrella is this? It ____ to someone who sat in the front row.

Correct answer: (B) belongs

Why: 'Belong' is a stative verb of possession and takes the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'is belonging' forces a stative verb into the continuous. Misconception: -ing with 'belong'.

• **(C)** 'belong' does not agree with the singular subject 'it'. Misconception: subject-verb mismatch.

• **(D)** 'is belonged' is not a valid form. Misconception: inventing a passive of 'belong'.

Principle: 'Belong', 'own', and 'possess' are stative.

Intuition hook: Something 'belongs' to you; it is never 'belonging'.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb 'belong'

Q146. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'These new football boots are costing far too much for me.'

Correct answer: These new football boots cost far too much for me.

Why: 'Cost' as a price is a stative fact and takes the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'are costing' treats a fixed price as an ongoing action. Misconception: continuous with a price verb.

Principle: 'Cost' as a price is stative.

Intuition hook: The boots 'cost' too much; a price does not happen in progress.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb 'cost'

Q147. (Multiple choice) In which sentence is 'am thinking' used correctly?

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'Think of / think about' meaning 'consider' is a dynamic process, so the continuous is correct; the other sentences use 'think' to mean 'have an opinion', which is stative.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'think (that)' = opinion; use 'I think he is the best captain'. Misconception: continuous with 'think = opinion'.
- **(C)** 'think that' = opinion; use 'I think water is wet'. Misconception: continuous with a stated belief.
- **(D)** 'think this film is boring' = opinion; use 'I think'. Misconception: continuous with a judgement.

Principle: 'Think of/about' (consider) is dynamic; 'think that' (have an opinion) is stative.

Intuition hook: Weighing a choice = 'I'm thinking about'; holding a view = 'I think'.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Dynamic vs. stative 'think'

Q148. (Fill in the blank) She ____ (want) to become a doctor ever since she was five years old.

Correct answer: has wanted

Why: 'Ever since' calls for the present perfect, and because 'want' is stative, we use the simple present perfect ('has wanted'), not the continuous.

Distractor analysis:

- 'has been wanting' adds the continuous to a stative verb; standard English keeps stative verbs out of the continuous, so 'has wanted' is preferred. Misconception: perfect continuous with a desire verb.

Principle: Stative verbs use the present perfect simple, not the present perfect continuous, even with 'since / for'.

Intuition hook: 'Has wanted for years', not 'has been wanting'.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb in the present perfect

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Q149. (Multiple choice) We ____ a little more time to finish this project properly.

Correct answer: (B) need

Why: 'Need' is a stative verb and takes the simple present.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'are needing' forces a stative verb into the continuous. Misconception: -ing with 'need'.
- **(C)** 'needs' does not agree with 'we'. Misconception: subject-verb mismatch.
- **(D)** 'is needing' is both continuous and wrong in agreement. Misconception: -ing plus wrong subject.

Principle: Verbs of necessity and desire (need, want) are stative.

Intuition hook: You 'need' something; you are never 'needing' it.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb 'need'

Q150. (Correct the sentence) Correct this sentence: 'Right now, I am wanting a tall glass of cold water.'

Correct answer: Right now, I want a tall glass of cold water.

Why: Even with 'right now', the stative verb 'want' takes the simple present, because stative verbs resist the continuous in every case.

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'am wanting' lets the trigger 'right now' override the stative rule. Misconception: assuming 'right now' always forces the continuous, even with stative verbs.

Principle: A stative verb stays in the simple present even when a 'now' word appears.

Intuition hook: 'Right now' cannot rescue a stative verb: it is still 'I want'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verb overrides 'right now'

Q151. (Multiple choice) Choose the fully correct sentence.

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'See' here means 'understand / perceive' (stative), and 'want' is stative, so both take the simple present; 'you are upset' correctly describes a state.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'am seeing' and 'am wanting' force two stative verbs into the continuous. Misconception: -ing with perceive and desire verbs.

• **(C)** 'you are upsetting' is wrong (it means you are upsetting someone else), and 'am wanting' is still continuous. Misconception: mixing up 'upset' as a state vs. an action, plus stative continuous.

• **(D)** 'am seeing' is continuous, and 'you upset' is not a complete state description. Misconception: continuous stative plus a broken clause.

Principle: Apply the stative rule to every verb in the sentence: perceive and desire verbs stay simple present.

Intuition hook: 'I see, I want' – not 'I am seeing, I am wanting'.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative rule across a whole sentence

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Q152. (Explain the error) Explain why 'I am seeing the doctor tomorrow' is correct, but 'I am seeing a rainbow right now' is wrong. Give the correct form of the second sentence.

Correct answer: 'See' has two uses. 'I am seeing the doctor tomorrow' uses 'see' to mean 'meet by appointment' (a dynamic, arranged action, so the present continuous is fine). 'See' meaning 'perceive with the eyes' is stative, so the correct form is 'I see a rainbow right now'.

Why: The same verb can be dynamic in one meaning and stative in another. 'See = meet' behaves like a planned action; 'see = perceive' behaves like a state.

Distractor analysis:

• Treating both as the same misses that 'see' switches between a dynamic meaning (meet) and a stative meaning (perceive). Misconception: assuming a verb has only one behaviour.

Principle: One verb can be dynamic or stative depending on meaning; only the dynamic meaning takes the continuous.

Intuition hook: 'Seeing the doctor' (meeting) is fine; 'seeing a rainbow' (perceiving) is not – just 'I see it'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Dynamic vs. stative meanings of 'see'

Section H — Sequence, Consistency and Narrative Tense

Q153. (Paragraph editing) This story is told in the past tense, but one verb is in the wrong tense. Find it and write the correct form. 'Last Saturday, Mia woke up early and made breakfast for everyone. After they ate, the family drove to the lake. Mia jumps into the cold water and laughed with her brothers all afternoon.'

Correct answer: 'jumps' should be 'jumped'.

Why: Every other verb (woke, made, ate, drove, laughed) is in the simple past, so 'jumps' breaks the narrative. Once a story is set in the past, all its main actions stay in the past unless there is a clear reason to shift.

Distractor analysis:

• Leaving 'jumps' in the present clashes with the past-tense story around it. Misconception: shifting into the present in the middle of a past narrative, often because the moment feels vivid.

Principle: Keep a narrative in one time frame: a past-tense story keeps its actions in the past.

Intuition hook: Don't let one exciting verb jump into the present – keep the whole story in the past.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Narrative tense consistency

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Q154. (Order the events) Read the sentence, then number the two events 1 (happened first) and 2 (happened second): 'When the firefighters arrived, the family had already escaped from the burning house.' ( ) The firefighters arrived. ( ) The family escaped.

Correct answer: 1 = The family escaped; 2 = The firefighters arrived.

Why: The past perfect 'had already escaped' marks the earlier event. So the family escaped first, and the firefighters arrived afterwards.

Distractor analysis:

• Numbering them in sentence order (firefighters first) ignores the past perfect. Misconception: assuming events always happen in the order they are written, rather than reading the tense.

Principle: The past perfect ('had' + past participle) marks the earlier of two past events.

Intuition hook: 'Had escaped' = the earlier action, no matter where it sits in the sentence.

Difficulty: 3/10 | Cognitive skill: Sequencing with the past perfect

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Q155. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best sets the background scene. 'As we walked into the garden, the birds ___ in the trees.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: The singing was already going on when the point event 'we walked in' happened, so the ongoing background action takes the past continuous 'were singing'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'sang' suggests the birds sang at the single moment we entered, not that singing was already in progress. Misconception: using the simple past for background action that was already underway.

• **(C)** 'have sung' is present perfect and breaks the past narrative. Misconception: mixing present perfect into a past story.

• **(D)** 'sing' is the simple present and does not fit a past story at all. Misconception: dropping out of the past frame.

Principle: Use the past continuous for a longer background action that was already happening when a shorter action interrupted it.

Intuition hook: The birds were already singing when we walked in – ongoing background = 'were singing'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Background scene-setting with past continuous

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Q156. (Spot the error) One sentence in this paragraph shifts to the wrong tense. Write the sentence number and correct the verb. '(1) The old lighthouse stood on the cliff for a hundred years. (2) One stormy night, the keeper climbed the stairs to light the lamp. (3) Suddenly, the wind blows out his candle. (4) He fumbled in the dark until he found the matches.'

Correct answer: Sentence (3): 'blows' should be 'blew'.

Why: Sentences (1), (2) and (4) all use the simple past (stood, climbed, fumbled, found). Sentence (3) slips into the present with 'blows', so it must become 'blew' to match.

Distractor analysis:

• Leaving 'blows' in the present breaks the past-tense story. Misconception: switching to the present for a dramatic moment inside a past narrative.

Principle: A single present-tense verb inside a past narrative is an error; match the surrounding past tense.

Intuition hook: Scan for the odd verb out: everything is past, so 'blows' must be 'blew'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Spotting a tense shift

Q157. (Paragraph editing) Fill each blank with the correct past-tense form to keep the narrative consistent. 'The detective ___ (enter) the room and ___ (look) around carefully. Nothing ___ (seem) out of place, but she ___ (know) that something was wrong.'

Correct answer: entered; looked; seemed; knew

Why: The action verbs 'enter' and 'look' become the simple past 'entered' and 'looked'. The stative verbs 'seem' and 'know' also take the simple past ('seemed', 'knew') – stative verbs still shift tense; they simply do not take the continuous.

Distractor analysis:

• Writing 'was seeming' or 'was knowing' forces stative verbs into the continuous. Misconception: thinking stative verbs cannot change tense, when in fact they take the simple past normally.

Principle: In a past narrative, stative verbs take the simple past ('seemed', 'knew'), not the past continuous.

Intuition hook: 'Seemed' and 'knew' – stative verbs move to the past simply, never '-ing'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Stative verbs in past narrative

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Q158. (Complete the dialogue) Read the dialogue and choose the correct option. Ben: 'You look exhausted!' Sam: 'I know. I ___ since six o'clock this morning.' Which best completes Sam's line?

Correct answer: (A)

Why: 'Since six o'clock this morning' marks a period stretching from a past point up to now, and the tiredness is a present result, so the present perfect continuous 'have been studying' fits.

Distractor analysis:

• **(B)** 'studied' is the simple past, which cannot combine with 'since' for a period reaching the present. Misconception: using the simple past with 'since'.

• **(C)** 'was studying' is past continuous and also cannot take 'since' up to now. Misconception: pairing a past tense with a present-reaching 'since'.

• **(D)** 'study' is the simple present and does not express an activity continuing up to now. Misconception: using the simple present for a recent ongoing activity.

Principle: 'Since' + a starting point, with a present result, calls for the present perfect (continuous), not a simple past.

Intuition hook: 'Since six o'clock' reaches up to now – that needs 'have been', not 'studied'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Since' forcing present perfect in dialogue

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Q159. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that correctly sequences the two past events. 'By the time the guests arrived, my mother ___ the entire meal.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'By the time the guests arrived' sets a past point, and the cooking was finished before that point, so the earlier completed action takes the past perfect 'had cooked'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'cooked' does not show that the cooking finished before the arrival – it just places both in the past. Misconception: using the simple past where sequence needs the past perfect.

• **(C)** 'was cooking' means she was still in the middle of cooking, which clashes with completing 'the entire meal' before the guests arrived. Misconception: using the continuous for a completed earlier action.

• **(D)** 'cooks' is the simple present and does not fit a past frame. Misconception: leaving the past narrative.

Principle: 'By the time' + a past event calls for the past perfect for the action completed earlier.

Intuition hook: The meal was done before they arrived – earlier-and-finished = 'had cooked'.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect with 'by the time'

Q160. (Timeline reasoning) Describe a simple timeline (earliest to now) that places these events in order, based on the sentence: 'I had lived in three different cities before I moved to London, where I have lived ever since.'

Correct answer: Earliest: living in three different cities (past perfect 'had lived', before the move). Next: moving to London (simple past 'moved'). Then continuing up to the present: living in London ever since (present perfect 'have lived').

Why: Three layers of time appear: the past perfect for the earliest stretch, the simple past for the key past event, and the present perfect for the situation that continues to now.

Distractor analysis:

• Flattening all three into one tense loses the order. Misconception: not seeing that past perfect, simple past and present perfect mark three different time layers.

Principle: Past perfect (before) → simple past (the event) → present perfect (up to now) can stack to show a full sequence.

Intuition hook: Before London (had lived) → moved to London (moved) → still there (have lived).

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Layering three past/perfect tenses

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Q161. (Correct the sentence) Correct the tense error in this sentence: 'While I was walked to school, I saw a fox cross the road.'

Correct answer: 'was walked' should be 'was walking'.

Why: The background action interrupted by the point event 'I saw a fox' should be the past continuous 'was walking'. 'Was walked' is an incorrect form (it looks passive and does not fit here).

Distractor analysis:

• Keeping 'was walked' leaves an ungrammatical form for the ongoing background action. Misconception: confusing 'was walking' (past continuous) with 'was walked' (a passive-looking form).

Principle: Use the past continuous ('was walking') for the ongoing action that another action interrupts.

Intuition hook: You were in the middle of walking when you saw the fox – 'was walking'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Past continuous for interrupted background

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Q162. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that keeps the sentence consistent. 'She opened the fridge, took out the milk, and ___ herself a glass.'

Correct answer: (C)

Why: The sentence lists a chain of completed actions in the simple past (opened, took), so the third action must match with the simple past 'poured'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'pours' is the simple present and breaks the past chain. Misconception: shifting to the present mid-sentence.

• **(B)** 'had poured' wrongly places the pouring before the earlier actions, but it actually comes last. Misconception: overusing the past perfect for an action that is not earlier.

• **(D)** 'was pouring' turns the final quick action into an ongoing one, breaking the parallel list of completed actions. Misconception: using the continuous inside a sequence of finished steps.

Principle: A chain of sequential completed actions stays in the simple past throughout.

Intuition hook: Opened, took, poured – keep the three steps in the same simple past.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Parallel simple-past sequence

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Q163. (Are both acceptable?) Both sentences are grammatically correct. Explain how their meanings differ. (1) 'When I got home, my sister made dinner.' (2) 'When I got home, my sister had made dinner.'

Correct answer: In (1), 'made' (simple past) suggests my sister made dinner at or after the time I got home – the two events are close together, and she cooked once I arrived. In (2), 'had made' (past perfect) shows dinner was already finished before I got home – the cooking happened earlier.

Why: The past perfect pushes one action clearly before the other. Without it, the simple past lets the two events sit at roughly the same time, with dinner following the arrival.

Distractor analysis:

• Treating them as identical misses that the past perfect ('had made') moves the cooking to before the arrival. Misconception: assuming the past perfect changes nothing.

Principle: Adding the past perfect signals that one past action was completed before another.

Intuition hook: 'Had made' = dinner was ready before you walked in; 'made' = she cooked once you were home.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Meaning of optional past perfect

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Q164. (Rewrite (keep the meaning)) Rewrite this present-tense narrative in the past tense, keeping it consistent: 'Tom wakes up, sees the snow, and runs outside. He builds a snowman while his dog watches.'

Correct answer: 'Tom woke up, saw the snow, and ran outside. He built a snowman while his dog watched.'

Why: Each verb moves to its past form: wakes→woke, sees→saw, runs→ran, builds→built, watches→watched. The whole passage stays in the past. ('while his dog was watching' is also acceptable.)

Distractor analysis:

• Leaving any verb in the present (for example 'sees') breaks the past narrative, and using the wrong irregular form (such as 'runned') is a separate error. Misconception: forgetting irregular past forms or shifting tense partway.

Principle: When converting a story to the past, change every main verb consistently, including irregulars.

Intuition hook: Woke, saw, ran, built, watched – move them all together into the past.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Converting a narrative to consistent past

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Q165. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that correctly completes this email. 'Dear Aunt Sara, Thank you for the birthday gift, which ___ yesterday. I love it! I will visit you next month to thank you in person.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'Yesterday' is a finished past time, so the simple past 'arrived' is required. The present 'I love it' and the future 'I will visit' around it are already correct; only this blank tests the past-time rule.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'arrives' is the simple present and does not fit a finished 'yesterday'. Misconception: using the present for a completed past event.

• **(C)** 'has arrived' is present perfect, which cannot combine with the specific past time 'yesterday'. Misconception: using the present perfect with a finished time word.

• **(D)** 'had arrived' is the past perfect, but there is no earlier past event for it to relate to. Misconception: using the past perfect with no second past reference point.

Principle: A specific finished time such as 'yesterday' calls for the simple past.

Intuition hook: 'Yesterday' pins it to finished time – 'arrived'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past with finished-time marker

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Q166. (Spot the error) This diary entry has one verb in the wrong tense. Find it and correct it, keeping the past narrative consistent. 'Dear Diary, Today was amazing. We drive to the beach and swam in the sea. I collected shells while my dad read his book. I felt so happy!'

Correct answer: 'drive' should be 'drove'.

Why: The entry recounts finished events of the day in the simple past (was, swam, collected, read, felt). 'Drive' is the only present-tense verb, so it must become 'drove'.

Distractor analysis:

• Leaving 'drive' in the present breaks the past account of the day. Misconception: slipping into the present when narrating completed events.

Principle: A diary recounting the day's finished events keeps every verb in the past.

Intuition hook: One present verb spoils the past entry – 'drive' must be 'drove'.

Difficulty: 4/10 | Cognitive skill: Spotting a shift in a diary entry

---

Q167. (Choose the context) Select the verb form that best fits the ongoing story. 'The children had been playing outside for hours. By dinnertime they ___ tired and hungry.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: The story is set in the past, and 'by dinnertime they ___ tired' describes their state at that past point, so the simple past 'were' fits.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'are' is the simple present and breaks the past frame. Misconception: dropping into the present in a past story.

• **(C)** 'have been' is present perfect, which links to now rather than to the past dinnertime. Misconception: connecting a past scene to the present.

• **(D)** 'had been' is past perfect, but there is no later past event that this state comes before, so it over-backshifts. Misconception: using the past perfect with nothing later to anchor it.

Principle: Describe a state at a past point in time with the simple past.

Intuition hook: At past dinnertime they simply 'were' tired – a plain past state.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past for a state at a past point

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Q168. (Paragraph editing) Fill the blanks so this notice reads correctly. 'The library ___ (be) closed last week for repairs. It ___ (reopen) yesterday, and it ___ (be) now open at its usual hours.'

Correct answer: was; reopened; is

Why: Each blank has its own time marker: 'last week' → past state 'was closed'; 'yesterday' → past event 'reopened'; 'now' → present state 'is open'. Consistency here means matching each verb to its own time, not making them all the same tense.

Distractor analysis:

• Forcing all three verbs into one tense ignores the different time markers ('last week', 'yesterday', 'now'). Misconception: thinking 'consistent' means 'identical', rather than each verb fitting its own time.

Principle: Consistency means each verb matches its own time marker – past for past, present for now.

Intuition hook: Last week (was), yesterday (reopened), now (is) – each time gets its own tense.

Difficulty: 5/10 | Cognitive skill: Matching tense to each time marker

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Q169. (Multiple choice) Choose the correct option. 'The film ___ by the time we found our seats; we had missed the opening scene.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'By the time we found our seats' sets a past point, and the film had begun before it (confirmed by 'we had missed the opening scene'), so the earlier action takes the past perfect 'had already started'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'already started' lacks the 'had' needed to show it happened before we sat down. Misconception: using the simple past where the past perfect marks the earlier event.

• **(C)** 'was already starting' describes the film in the act of beginning, but the context (we had already missed the opening) shows it had begun earlier. Misconception: using the continuous for an action that was already complete enough to be missed.

• **(D)** 'already starts' is the simple present and does not fit the past frame. Misconception: leaving the past narrative.

Principle: Use the past perfect for an event completed before another past event, especially with 'by the time'.

Intuition hook: It had started before we sat down – earlier past = 'had already started'.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect for an earlier event

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Q170. (Compare the sentences) Explain the difference in meaning between these two correct sentences. (1) 'When the bell rang, the students left the classroom.' (2) 'When the bell rang, the students were leaving the classroom.'

Correct answer: In (1), 'left' (simple past) means the bell rang first and the students left afterwards – the ringing triggered their exit. In (2), 'were leaving' (past continuous) means the students were already in the middle of leaving when the bell rang – the leaving was already underway.

Why: The simple past presents two events in sequence (ring, then leave); the past continuous makes one action the ongoing background against which the other happens.

Distractor analysis:

• Treating them as the same misses that the continuous shows leaving already in progress, while the simple past shows it happening after the bell. Misconception: ignoring how the past continuous signals an action already underway.

Principle: Simple past = one action then the next; past continuous = an action already in progress when another occurs.

Intuition hook: 'Left' = bell, then out; 'were leaving' = already heading out when it rang.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Simple past vs past continuous in sequence

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Q171. (Fill in the blank) Complete the paragraph with suitable past forms. Where two tenses are possible, either is accepted. 'The storm ___ (rage) all night. When we ___ (wake) up, the garden ___ (be) full of broken branches.'

Correct answer: had been raging (or raged); woke; was

Why: 'All night' up to the moment of waking suits the past perfect continuous 'had been raging', though the simple past 'raged' is acceptable. 'Woke' is the simple past point event, and 'was' is the past state of the garden.

Distractor analysis:

• Writing 'wakes' or 'is' breaks the past frame. Misconception: mixing present tense into a past paragraph, or failing to see that 'all night' allows the past perfect continuous.

Principle: A duration leading up to a past point suits the past perfect continuous, with the simple past often acceptable.

Intuition hook: It had been raging all night up to when we woke; then the garden simply was a mess.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect continuous in narrative

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Q172. (Order the events) Number these events 1-3 in the order they actually happened, using the tense clues: 'Before she went on stage, she had rehearsed her lines, which her teacher had written

for her.' ( ) She went on stage. ( ) Her teacher wrote the lines. ( ) She rehearsed her lines.

Correct answer: 1 = Her teacher wrote the lines; 2 = She rehearsed her lines; 3 = She went on stage.

Why: The lines had to exist before she could rehearse them, so the teacher's writing ('had written') is earliest. She rehearsed ('had rehearsed') before going on stage, and 'before she went on stage' places the stage appearance last.

Distractor analysis:

• Ordering them as written (stage first) ignores that both past-perfect actions happened before the stage appearance, and that writing must precede rehearsing. Misconception: reading order instead of tense and logic.

Principle: Two past-perfect actions both precede the simple-past event; logic then orders them relative to each other.

Intuition hook: Written → rehearsed → on stage: you need the lines before you practise, and practice before the show.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Ordering multiple past-perfect events

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Q173. (Spot the error) This paragraph is written in the past tense, but it contains exactly one tense error. Give the sentence number and the correction. '(1) When we arrived at the campsite, the sun was setting behind the hills. (2) We quickly put up our tent before it got dark. (3) While my father lit the fire, my sister and I collect firewood. (4) Later, we sat around the fire and told stories until we fell asleep.'

Correct answer: Sentence (3): 'collect' should be 'collected'.

Why: Sentence (1) uses the past continuous correctly for the background ('was setting'), and the rest use the simple past (put, got, lit, sat, told, fell). Only 'collect' is present, so it must become 'collected'.

Distractor analysis:

• Marking 'was setting' as the error misreads a correct background past continuous; the real error is the present-tense 'collect'. Misconception: mistaking a correct past continuous for a mistake, or overlooking the lone present-tense verb.

Principle: In a past paragraph, a correct past continuous is fine; the error is the verb that slips into the present.

Intuition hook: 'Was setting' is good background; 'collect' is the odd present verb – make it 'collected'.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Spotting one error among mixed past forms

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Q174. (Short writing) Write two or three sentences continuing this story. Keep the whole passage in the past tense. 'The knight opened the heavy wooden door and stepped into the dark tower...'

Correct answer: (Sample answer) 'Inside, he found a narrow staircase that spiralled upward. He climbed slowly, holding his torch high, until he reached a locked room at the top. From behind the door, he heard a strange, low humming.'

Why: A strong continuation keeps every main verb in the past (found, climbed, reached, heard) and may use the past continuous for background ('was humming', or an '-ing' phrase such as 'holding his torch high'). The key is not to slip into the present.

Distractor analysis:

• A weak answer drifts into the present ('he finds a staircase') or mixes tenses without reason. Misconception: losing the past frame once the writing becomes vivid or fast-paced.

Principle: Sustained narrative writing keeps a single past frame, using the past continuous only for background.

Intuition hook: Whatever happens next, keep telling it in the past – found, climbed, heard.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: Sustained past-tense narrative writing

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Section I — Expert Diagnostic Challenge

Q175. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'As soon as the download ___, the program will install itself automatically.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'As soon as' introduces a future time clause, and English never uses 'will' inside such a clause – the simple present 'finishes' carries the future meaning, while the main clause keeps 'will install'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'will finish' puts 'will' inside the time clause, which is not allowed. Misconception: repeating 'will' in both clauses because both actions are in the future.
- **(C)** 'will have finished' also wrongly uses a future form in the time clause. Misconception: reaching for the future perfect where a simple present is required.
- **(D)** 'is finishing' is present continuous and does not express the completed trigger the sentence needs. Misconception: using the continuous for a one-off completion.

Principle: After 'as soon as', 'when', 'until', 'once' and similar, use the simple present for future meaning – never 'will'.

Intuition hook: 'As soon as' bars 'will' – the clause takes plain present 'finishes'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: No 'will' in future time clauses

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Q176. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'By the time you read this note, I ___ for the airport.'

Correct answer: (C)

Why: The reading happens at a future point, and the leaving will be completed before that point, so the future perfect 'will have left' is correct. (Note 'read' in the time clause is the simple present, correctly avoiding 'will'.)

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'will leave' does not show that the departure is finished before the reading – it just places it in the future. Misconception: using the simple future where completion-before-a-future-point is meant.
- **(B)** 'leave' is the simple present and belongs in the time clause, not the main clause here. Misconception: mismatching which clause takes the present.
- **(D)** 'am leaving' describes an arrangement but does not locate the action as complete before the future reading. Misconception: using the arrangement present for a completed-by-then action.

Principle: Use the future perfect for an action that will be finished before a stated future point.

Intuition hook: Done before you even read it – 'will have left'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Future perfect before a future point

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Q177. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'I ___ Anna since we were children; she is my oldest friend.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'Since we were children' marks a period from the past up to now, which calls for the present perfect; and because 'know' is stative, the continuous is impossible, leaving 'have known'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'know' is the simple present and cannot take 'since' for a period reaching now. Misconception: using the simple present with a 'since' period.
- **(C)** 'have been knowing' forces the stative verb 'know' into the continuous. Misconception: applying the present perfect continuous to a stative verb.

• **(D)** 'am knowing' is present continuous with a stative verb, which is not allowed. Misconception: using '-ing' with 'know'.

Principle: 'Since' up to now needs the present perfect; a stative verb blocks the continuous, so use the simple present perfect.

Intuition hook: 'Since we were children' + a stative verb = 'have known', never 'been knowing'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect + stative verb

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Q178. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'If the medicine ___ within an hour, call the doctor immediately.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: This is a first conditional: the 'if' clause takes the simple present 'does not work', and 'will' (or 'would') never appears in the 'if' clause of a real future condition.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will not work' puts 'will' inside the 'if' clause, which is not allowed. Misconception: using 'will' in the condition because the outcome is in the future.

• **(C)** 'is not working' is present continuous and does not fit a general future condition here. Misconception: using the continuous for a simple conditional outcome.

• **(D)** 'would not work' belongs to a hypothetical (second conditional), not this real future instruction. Misconception: mixing the unreal conditional into a real one.

Principle: In a first conditional, the 'if' clause takes the simple present – no 'will' and no 'would'.

Intuition hook: 'If' clauses about the real future stay in the present – 'does not work'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: No 'will' in first-conditional 'if' clauses

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Q179. (Ambiguity analysis) The sentence 'I have been reading your book' can suggest two different things depending on the situation. Explain both, and give a context for each.

Correct answer: It can mean (1) the reading is still going on – I have not finished the book yet (context: 'I have been reading your book and I am halfway through – it is brilliant so far'); or (2) the reading has just stopped, with a present result (context: 'Sorry my eyes are tired – I have been reading your book all evening'). The present perfect continuous can point either to an activity continuing now or to one that has just finished and explains the present situation.

Why: The present perfect continuous links a recent activity to the present. Whether the activity is still ongoing or just completed depends on the surrounding context, which is why the bare sentence is open to two readings.

Distractor analysis:

• Assuming it can only mean 'still reading' misses the 'just finished, present result' reading. Misconception: thinking the present perfect continuous always means the action continues now.

Principle: The present perfect continuous can mean either an activity still in progress or one just finished with present relevance.

Intuition hook: 'Have been reading' – still going, or just stopped and it shows. Context decides.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Ambiguity of the present perfect continuous

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Q180. (Choose ALL correct answers) Select ALL the sentences that are grammatically correct.

Correct answer: (B), (C), and (E)

Why: (B) pairs the simple past with 'yesterday'; (C) pairs the present perfect with 'for years' up to now (and 'know' correctly stays simple); (E) uses the simple present in the time clause and the future perfect in the main clause. These follow the rules.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'have seen' cannot combine with the finished time 'yesterday'; it should be 'I saw him yesterday'. Misconception: present perfect with a specific past time.

• **(D)** 'am knowing' forces the stative verb 'know' into the continuous; it should be 'I know the answer'. Misconception: '-ing' with a stative verb.

Principle: Correct sentences respect the finished-time rule, the stative rule, and the no-'will'-in-time-clauses rule together.

Intuition hook: Keep the past with 'yesterday', keep 'know' simple, and drop 'will' from the time clause.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Combining multiple tense rules

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Q181. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that correctly completes this formal sentence. 'Scarcely ___ the concert begun when the power suddenly went out.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: After a negative or limiting adverb like 'scarcely', 'hardly' or 'no sooner' placed at the front, the verb inverts and uses the past perfect: 'Scarcely had the concert begun...'. The earlier action (the concert beginning) takes 'had begun'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'has' is present perfect and clashes with the past event 'went out'. Misconception: using a present form in a past narrative.

• **(C)** 'did' cannot combine with the past participle 'begun' in this structure. Misconception: mixing 'did' with a participle.

• **(D)** 'was' would need an '-ing' form, not 'begun', and does not fit this inversion. Misconception: using the past continuous where the past perfect is required.

Principle: 'Scarcely / Hardly / No sooner' at the front trigger inversion with the past perfect for the earlier action.

Intuition hook: 'Scarcely had it begun...' – front adverb pulls in inverted 'had begun'.

Difficulty: 9/10 | Cognitive skill: Inversion with the past perfect

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Q182. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'This time next week, I ___ on a beach in Spain.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'This time next week' names a point in the future, and the sentence pictures an action in progress at that moment, so the future continuous 'will be lying' is correct.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will lie' states a future fact but loses the 'in progress at that moment' picture. Misconception: using the simple future where an action is pictured mid-flow.

• **(C)** 'lie' is the simple present and does not fit a future point. Misconception: using the present for a clearly future situation.

• **(D)** 'am lying' suggests a fixed arrangement, which is odd for relaxing on a beach and does not capture 'in progress at that future moment'. Misconception: using the arrangement present for an in-progress future action.

Principle: Use the future continuous for an action that will be in progress at a specific future time.

Intuition hook: Picture yourself mid-action next week – 'will be lying'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Future continuous at a future point

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Q183. (Which is better?) You have already decided to sell your bike. A friend asks about your plans. Which reply is better, and why? (1) 'I think I'll sell my bike.' (2) 'I'm going to sell my bike.'

Correct answer: (2) 'I'm going to sell my bike' is better, because 'going to' expresses a decision or intention already made, which matches 'you have already decided'. (1) 'I think I'll' sounds like a decision made at the moment of speaking, which does not fit a plan you had made beforehand.

Why: 'Will' (especially 'I think I'll') often marks an instant decision, while 'going to' reports a prior intention. Since the decision was already made, 'going to' is the natural choice.

Distractor analysis:

• Choosing (1) treats a pre-made plan as a spur-of-the-moment decision. Misconception: using 'I think I'll' for intentions formed earlier.

Principle: 'Going to' reports a decision made before speaking; 'will' often marks a decision made while speaking.

Intuition hook: Already decided? Say 'going to'. Deciding right now? Say 'I'll'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: 'Going to' for prior intention vs 'will'

Q184. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'Wait here until I ___ back.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'Until' introduces a future time clause, so the verb takes the simple present 'come', not a future form – the same rule as 'when' and 'as soon as'.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will come' uses 'will' inside the time clause, which is not allowed. Misconception: putting 'will' after 'until'.

• **(C)** 'will have come' is a future form and also cannot follow 'until' here. Misconception: reaching for the future perfect in a time clause.

• **(D)** 'am coming' is present continuous and does not fit this instruction. Misconception: using the continuous for a simple future point after 'until'.

Principle: 'Until' takes the simple present for future meaning – no 'will'.

Intuition hook: 'Until I come back' – the time clause stays in the present.

Difficulty: 6/10 | Cognitive skill: No 'will' after 'until'

Q185. (Explain the error) Explain why 'I have lost my keys' is different from 'I lost my keys', and describe a situation where only the first is appropriate.

Correct answer: 'I have lost my keys' (present perfect) stresses the present result: the keys are still missing now, so I still cannot get in. 'I lost my keys' (simple past) simply reports a finished event, which may already be resolved (perhaps I found them later). Only the present perfect fits a situation like standing at a locked door right now, unable to enter, where the loss still matters at this moment.

Why: The present perfect connects a past event to the present situation; the simple past just places the event in finished time without saying anything about now.

Distractor analysis:

• Treating the two as identical misses that the present perfect signals a result that still holds now. Misconception: ignoring present relevance.

Principle: The present perfect ties a past event to a present result; the simple past merely reports the finished event.

Intuition hook: 'Have lost' = still can't find them now; 'lost' = it happened, maybe fixed since.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Present relevance vs finished report

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Q186. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'We ___ in this town for twenty years, and we love it here.'

Correct answer: (C)

Why: 'For twenty years' measures a period reaching up to the present, and 'we love it here' shows present relevance, so the present perfect 'have lived' is correct.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'live' is the simple present and cannot carry 'for twenty years' up to now. Misconception: using the simple present for a stretch of time reaching the present.
- **(B)** 'are living' suggests a temporary situation, which clashes with a settled twenty-year stay. Misconception: using the continuous for a long-term, permanent-feeling situation.
- **(D)** 'had lived' is the past perfect, but there is no later past event for it to precede. Misconception: using the past perfect with no second past point.

Principle: Use the present perfect for a period of time that began in the past and continues to now.

Intuition hook: Twenty years and still here – 'have lived'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Present perfect for duration up to now

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Q187. (Compare the sentences) You look outside and see wet streets. Both sentences are correct. Explain the different picture each one gives. (1) 'It has been raining.' (2) 'It has rained.'

Correct answer: (1) 'It has been raining' focuses on the activity and its recent duration – it emphasises the process (it rained for a while and may only just have stopped, or could still be drizzling), which explains the wet streets as a fresh, ongoing effect. (2) 'It has rained' focuses on the completed fact and its result – the rain is over, and the wet streets are the evidence left behind.

Why: The present perfect continuous highlights the ongoing activity; the present perfect simple highlights the finished result. Both connect to now, but from different angles: process versus outcome.

Distractor analysis:

- Saying they mean exactly the same misses the process-versus-result difference. Misconception: treating the continuous and simple perfect as interchangeable.

Principle: Present perfect continuous stresses the activity/duration; present perfect simple stresses the completed result.

Intuition hook: 'Has been raining' = the process you can almost still feel; 'has rained' = the finished fact behind the puddles.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Perfect continuous vs perfect simple picture

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Q188. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'I met her in 2010. Until then, I ___ anyone from that country.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'Until then' points back to a past moment (2010), and the sentence describes the situation before that past moment, so the past perfect 'hadn't met' is correct.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'didn't meet' does not show that this state existed up to and before the past point 2010. Misconception: using the simple past where 'before a past point' needs the past perfect.
- **(C)** 'haven't met' is present perfect and wrongly links to now, but she is someone I have already met. Misconception: connecting a closed past situation to the present.
- **(D)** 'don't meet' is the simple present and does not fit a past frame. Misconception: leaving the past narrative entirely.

Principle: Use the past perfect for a state that held up to a specific past point ('until then').

Intuition hook: Before 2010, that was already true – 'hadn't met'.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect for 'up to a past point'

Q189. (Choose the context) You want to describe a habit that annoyed you in the past but has now stopped. Which sentence fits best?

Correct answer: (B)

Why: The past continuous with 'always' expresses a repeated, irritating habit that happened over a past period and has now stopped, so 'He was always interrupting me' fits.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'is always interrupting' describes a present, still-continuing irritation, not a past one. Misconception: using the present for a habit that has stopped.
- **(C)** 'always interrupts' is a neutral present habit and still happening. Misconception: using the simple present for a finished past habit.
- **(D)** 'has always interrupted' suggests the habit continues up to now. Misconception: using the present perfect for a habit that has stopped.

Principle: Past continuous + 'always' expresses a repeated, annoying past habit that is now over.

Intuition hook: Annoying, repeated, and finished – 'was always interrupting'.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Past continuous with 'always' for past habit

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Q190. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'The moment the clock ___ midnight, the fireworks will begin.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: 'The moment' works like 'as soon as', introducing a future time clause, so the verb takes the simple present 'strikes', while the main clause keeps 'will begin'.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'will strike' puts 'will' in the time clause, which is not allowed. Misconception: doubling 'will' because both events are future.
- **(C)** 'will have struck' is a future form and cannot follow 'the moment' here. Misconception: using the future perfect in a time clause.
- **(D)** 'is striking' is present continuous and does not fit a punctual trigger. Misconception: using the continuous for a one-off, instantaneous event.

Principle: 'The moment', like 'as soon as', takes the simple present for future meaning – no 'will'.

Intuition hook: 'The moment it strikes' – time clause stays in the present.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: 'The moment' as a future time clause

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Q191. (Correct the sentence) Correct the one tense error in this sentence: 'By the time the ambulance arrived, the patient already stopped breathing, but the paramedics revived him.'

Correct answer: 'already stopped' should be 'had already stopped'.

Why: 'By the time the ambulance arrived' sets a past point, and the patient's breathing had stopped before it, so that earlier action needs the past perfect 'had already stopped'. 'Arrived' and 'revived' are correct simple pasts.

Distractor analysis:

- Leaving 'already stopped' as a simple past fails to mark it as the earlier of the past events. Misconception: not using the past perfect for an action completed before another past action, despite 'by the time'.

Principle: 'By the time' + a past event requires the past perfect for the action completed earlier.

Intuition hook: It had already stopped before they arrived – 'had stopped'.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect within 'by the time'

Q192. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'She ___ five cups of coffee today, and she still feels sleepy.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: A completed, counted quantity ('five cups') calls for the present perfect simple, and 'today' is an unfinished period reaching now, so 'has drunk' is correct.

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'has been drinking' emphasises an ongoing activity, but a fixed count of five finished cups calls for the simple perfect. Misconception: using the continuous when the result is a completed number.
- **(C)** 'drinks' is a neutral present habit and does not report today's completed cups. Misconception: using the simple present for a specific tally in an unfinished period.
- **(D)** 'is drinking' describes one cup in progress now, not five finished ones. Misconception: using the present continuous for a completed count.

Principle: Use the present perfect simple for a completed, counted result within an unfinished period.

Intuition hook: Five finished cups so far today – count it with 'has drunk'.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Perfect simple for completed count

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Q193. (Ambiguity analysis) The sentence 'When I got to the station, the train left.' is grammatically correct but can mislead. Explain the two possible interpretations, and show how the past perfect could remove any confusion.

Correct answer: One reading is that the train left at or just after I arrived – the two events happened close together, so I saw it pull away or just missed it. Another reading some people infer is that the train had already gone before I got there. To make the 'already gone before I arrived' meaning clear and unambiguous, use the past perfect: 'When I got to the station, the train had left.' Then 'left' means departed at/after my arrival, while 'had left' means it was gone before I arrived.

Why: The simple past 'left' places the two events at roughly the same time, which readers may interpret either way. The past perfect 'had left' fixes the departure firmly before the arrival, removing the ambiguity.

Distractor analysis:

- Assuming only one meaning is possible ignores how the plain simple past can be read two ways. Misconception: not seeing that the past perfect is what forces the 'earlier' reading.

Principle: Two simple-past events can read as simultaneous or sequential; the past perfect makes 'earlier' explicit.

Intuition hook: 'Left' = as/just after you arrived; 'had left' = gone before you got there.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Resolving sequence ambiguity with past perfect

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Q194. (Choose ALL correct answers) Select ALL the sentences that are correct.

Correct answer: (A), (C), and (D)

Why: (A) uses the present perfect for a present result ('so I can play now'); (C) uses it for life experience with 'ever'; (D) uses it with 'already' for a recent action with present relevance. These are all correct.

Distractor analysis:

- **(B)** 'an hour ago' is a finished past time, which cannot take the present perfect; it should be 'I finished my homework an hour ago'. Misconception: present perfect with a specific past time.
- **(E)** Columbus is long dead and this refers to a finished historical event, so it needs the simple past: 'Columbus discovered America'. Misconception: present perfect for a completed life or a fixed historical moment.

Principle: The present perfect needs present relevance and no finished-time marker; completed history takes the simple past.

Intuition hook: Result, experience, 'already' → present perfect; 'an hour ago' or dead-and-done history → simple past.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: When present perfect is and isn't allowed

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Q195. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'He promised he ___ me, but he never did.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: After the past reporting verb 'promised', 'will' shifts back to 'would' (future-in-the-past), so 'he would call me' is correct.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'will call' keeps the present-time 'will' after a past reporting verb, breaking the sequence. Misconception: not backshifting 'will' to 'would' after a past verb.

• **(C)** 'calls' is the simple present and does not fit a past promise. Misconception: leaving the reported clause in the present.

• **(D)** 'had called' (past perfect) wrongly suggests the calling happened before the promise, but the promise was about the future. Misconception: using the past perfect for a promised future action.

Principle: After a past reporting verb, 'will' becomes 'would' – future-in-the-past.

Intuition hook: A past promise about the future uses 'would call', not 'will call'.

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Backshifting 'will' to 'would'

Q196. (Which is better?) You have spent all day painting a fence; you are tired and covered in paint, and the job is now done. A friend asks what you have been up to. Which reply is more natural, and why? (1) 'I've painted the fence.' (2) 'I've been painting the fence.'

Correct answer: (2) 'I've been painting the fence' is more natural here, because the friend is asking how you spent your time, and the present perfect continuous highlights the ongoing activity that filled the day and explains your tired, paint-covered state. (1) 'I've painted the fence' simply reports the finished result and answers a different question ('is it done?').

Why: The present perfect continuous foregrounds the activity and its recent effects; the present perfect simple foregrounds the completed result. Given the emphasis on how you spent the time and your current state, the continuous is the better fit.

Distractor analysis:

• Choosing (1) answers 'is it finished?' rather than 'what have you been doing?'. Misconception: using the simple perfect when the focus is on the activity and its present effects.

Principle: Use the present perfect continuous when the focus is the recent activity and its present effects, not just the finished result.

Intuition hook: Explaining your tired, painty state? Emphasise the doing – 'I've been painting'.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Perfect continuous for activity focus

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Q197. (Multiple choice) Choose the option that best completes the sentence. 'When the coach finally arrived, the players ___ for two hours and were exhausted.'

Correct answer: (B)

Why: The duration 'for two hours' runs up to the past point 'when the coach arrived', and 'were exhausted' points to the tiring effect of the ongoing activity, so the past perfect continuous 'had been practising' fits best.

Distractor analysis:

• **(A)** 'had practised' reports a completed amount but does not stress the continuous effort that left them exhausted. Misconception: using the simple past perfect where the emphasis is on the ongoing activity and its result.

• **(C)** 'were practising' describes the action in progress but loses the 'before that point, for two hours' framing. Misconception: using the past continuous where a duration up to a past point is meant.

• **(D)** 'practised' is a plain simple past and does not show the two-hour stretch leading up to the arrival. Misconception: using the simple past for a duration up to a later past point.

Principle: Use the past perfect continuous for an activity that continued for a period up to a past point, especially when its effect is felt at that point.

Intuition hook: Two tiring hours up to the coach's arrival – 'had been practising'.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Past perfect continuous for duration-to-a-past-point

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Q198. (Choose the context) You are describing an appointment you have already arranged with the dentist for next Tuesday. Which sentence is the most natural?

Correct answer: (B)

Why: A fixed personal arrangement with a set time is most naturally expressed with the present continuous, so 'I am seeing the dentist on Tuesday' fits. (Here 'see' means 'meet by appointment', a dynamic use that allows the continuous.)

Distractor analysis:

- **(A)** 'will see' sounds like a prediction or an on-the-spot decision, not a fixed arrangement. Misconception: using 'will' for a plan already settled.
- **(C)** 'I see the dentist on Tuesday' fits a fixed timetable of public events more than a personal appointment. Misconception: using the timetable present for a personal arrangement.
- **(D)** 'will be seeing' is future continuous, which sounds less natural than the arrangement present for a set appointment. Misconception: using the future continuous where the arrangement present is idiomatic.

Principle: Use the present continuous for a fixed personal arrangement with a set time.

Intuition hook: Appointment already booked? 'I'm seeing the dentist on Tuesday.'

Difficulty: 7/10 | Cognitive skill: Present continuous for arrangements

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Q199. (Compare the sentences) Explain the difference in meaning between these three correct sentences. (1) 'I lived in Rome for three years.' (2) 'I have lived in Rome for three years.' (3) 'I had lived in Rome for three years before I moved to Milan.'

Correct answer: (1) Simple past: the three years are finished and I no longer live in Rome. (2) Present perfect: I still live in Rome now, and the three years continue up to the present. (3) Past perfect: measured up to a past point (moving to Milan) – by that moment I had completed three years in Rome, and then I left. So the same phrase 'for three years' means finished-and-gone, still-continuing, or completed-before-another-past-event, depending on the tense.

Why: The three tenses locate the same duration differently: the simple past closes it in the past, the present perfect runs it up to now, and the past perfect completes it before a later past event.

Distractor analysis:

- Blurring the three together loses the crucial 'finished / still true / finished-before-a-past-point' distinctions. Misconception: assuming 'for three years' means the same regardless of tense.

Principle: Simple past closes a duration; present perfect runs it up to now; past perfect completes it before another past event.

Intuition hook: Gone (lived) – still here (have lived) – done before Milan (had lived).

Difficulty: 9/10 | Cognitive skill: Contrasting three tenses on one duration

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Q200. (Short writing) In three or four sentences, describe your day yesterday, from waking up to going to bed. Use at least one simple past, one past continuous, and one past perfect correctly, and label each of the three (write the tense name in brackets after the verb).

Correct answer: (Sample answer) 'I woke up (simple past) late because I had forgotten (past perfect) to set my alarm. While I was eating (past continuous) breakfast, my friend called to invite me out. We spent the whole afternoon at the park and I got home happy and tired.'

Why: A strong answer weaves the three past-time tenses into one consistent story: the simple past for the main events, the past continuous for a background action, and the past perfect for something completed before another past moment. The whole passage should stay in the past.

Distractor analysis:

• A weak answer slips into the present, misuses a tense (for example a past perfect with no earlier reference), or fails to include all three required tenses. Misconception: not controlling the three past tenses together in a single coherent narrative.

Principle: Skilled past narration combines simple past, past continuous and past perfect coherently in one frame.

Intuition hook: Main events (woke), background (was eating), earlier cause (had forgotten) – braid all three.

Difficulty: 8/10 | Cognitive skill: Producing all three past tenses in context

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Diagnostic Interpretation Guide

Do not read this page as a simple score out of 200. Read it as a map of **where** the thinking breaks. Two students with the same score can have completely different mental models. What matters is the **pattern** of the mistakes.

Step 1: Score the bands

- **170–200:** Robust model. The student reasons from meaning and handles most traps. Focus on the few Level-3 misses and on speed.
- **140–169:** Solid but leaky. Rules are known; context sometimes loses to signal words. Target the specific sections below.
- **110–139:** Rule-bound. The student knows textbook rules but applies them mechanically. This is the most common and most fixable profile.
- **Below 110:** Fragile foundation under the surface knowledge. Rebuild the four core contrasts before adding nuance.

Step 2: Find the misconception clusters

Group the missed question numbers by the section they came from. A cluster of misses inside one section points to a specific broken idea, listed here:

- **Section A misses** → confusing 'now' with 'these days', or using continuous with stative verbs, or swapping present perfect for simple past.
- **Section B misses** → either over-using the past perfect where simple past is enough, or failing to mark which past event came first.
- **Section C misses** → treating 'will', 'going to', present continuous, and simple present as interchangeable futures.
- **Section D misses** → a shaky grasp of 'present relevance' and of since / for / by the time.
- **Section E misses** → the student is a signal-word follower who does not yet read the whole situation.
- **Section F misses** → the tense reasoning may be fine, but irregular participle forms (gone/went, seen/saw, begun/began) are shaky.
- **Section G misses** → the -ing form is being over-applied; the idea of a 'state' vs. an 'action' is not yet internalised.
- **Section H misses** → the student handles single sentences but loses tense control across a paragraph.
- **Section I misses (with earlier sections clean)** → the model is good; the gap is holding several ideas at once under pressure.

Step 3: Read the 'why', not just the 'what'

For every miss, have the student say out loud the misconception listed beside that question in the Answer Key. Naming the error is most of the cure. If the same misconception name appears three or more times, that is the first thing to fix.

Targeted Remediation Plan

Fix the model, then re-test. Work the drills in the order the diagnosis flags as weakest. Do not move on until the student can **explain** the choice, not just make it.

Drill 1 — The four core contrasts (do this first if score is below 110)

• For each pair, the student writes two of their own sentences and explains the difference: 'I eat' vs. 'I am eating'; 'I went' vs. 'I have gone'; 'I did' vs. 'I had done'; 'I will do' vs. 'I am going to do'.

Drill 2 — Meaning over signal words (for Section E weakness)

• Take ten sentences that contain 'yesterday', 'now', 'since', 'already'. Cover the signal word and ask: from the situation alone, what tense is needed? Then reveal the word and check whether it agrees. This breaks the reflex of answering from the marker.

Drill 3 — The stative-verb list (for Section G weakness)

• Memorise the core stative set: know, believe, understand, like, love, hate, want, own, belong, seem, prefer, remember. Then deliberately try to put each in the continuous and feel why it sounds wrong ('I am knowing' → wrong). The discomfort is the lesson.

Drill 4 — 'Which past came first?' (for Section B weakness)

• Give two past events in one sentence. The earlier one takes 'had + past participle'; the later one takes simple past. Draw a simple left-to-right time arrow on paper for five sentences until the ordering is automatic.

Drill 5 — The four futures (for Section C weakness)

• Sort twenty situations into: prediction ('will'), evidence-based prediction / intention ('going to'), fixed personal arrangement (present continuous), and timetable (simple present). The sorting itself teaches the difference.

Drill 6 — Paragraph consistency (for Section H weakness)

• Give the student a five-sentence story with one deliberately wrong tense shift. They find it, fix it, and explain why it broke. Then have them write their own short diary entry and check their own tense flow.

Weekly rhythm

Two short sessions a week beat one long one. Re-test with a fresh subset of these questions after two weeks. Track not the score but whether the **misconception names** stop reappearing. That disappearance, more than any number, is the real sign of a robust model and of genuine SAT-level readiness.